

Spanish, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one commute at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
`code/learning/human-languages/spanish/lessons/`

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). You may share
and adapt this work, including commercially, as long as you give
appropriate credit and license your own contributions under the same
terms.

Preface

This book teaches Spanish one word at a time — and it teaches each word by taking it apart. A huge fraction of Spanish vocabulary is not arbitrary: it is Latin, lightly worn by a thousand years of use, and English borrowed from the same Latin so often that the two languages are full of hidden cousins. So no word here is a fresh thing to memorize. *gracias* arrives next to *grace*, *gratitude*, *gratuity*, *ingrate*, and *congratulate* — a family you have owned your whole life. The bet is simple and, as far as we can tell, how the brain actually works: you learn the new by welding it to the known.

Three things follow from that, and shape every lesson:

- **One word per lesson, gone deep.** Not “the ten greetings” — *hola* is a lesson, *buenos días* is a lesson. A few minutes each, the size of a single errand or commute.
- **The widest honest web of cousins.** Every word reaches for all the English relatives it can *truthfully* claim — because the more live connections a word has, the more places it sticks. False cousins are flagged, not smuggled in.
- **The reason, not the rule.** Why is it *buenos días*, plural? Because it is the fossil of a blessing, “*may God give you good days.*” We learn the culture and the idiom hiding inside the grammar — the things Spanish 101 skips.

Pronunciation is a short reference at the front, not a gate: each lesson tells you the sounds it needs, when it needs them. A companion set of practice lessons — the same content sliced for spaced repetition in the car — lives beside this book in the repository. This book is the continuous read; those are the practice.

A living document, grown one word at a time, released under CC BY-SA 4.0 so that if it helps anyone else learn Spanish this way, they are free to use, adapt, and pass it on.

Contents

Preface	iii
Pronunciation (reference)	1
1 Hola and Buenos Días	3
1.1 hola	3
1.2 bien	4
1.3 el / la	6
1.4 el / la + noun	8
1.5 día	9
1.6 buenos días	10
1.7 Practice	12
2 The Rest of the Greetings	15
2.1 la tarde	15
2.2 buenas tardes	16
2.3 la noche	18
2.4 buenas noches	19
2.5 Practice	20
3 Introducing Yourself	23
3.1 me	23
3.2 llamo	24
3.3 me llamo	25
3.4 tú / usted	27
3.5 vuestra merced to usted	28
3.6 cómo	29
3.7 qu-	30
3.8 se llama	31
3.9 ¿cómo se llama usted?	33

3.10	mucho	34
3.11	mucho gusto	35
3.12	Practice	36
4	How Are You?	39
4.1	<i>gracias</i> — “thank you,” a whole English family	39
4.2	<i>de nada</i> — “you’re welcome,” or “it was nothing”	40
4.3	<i>estar</i> — “to be,” the <i>standing</i> kind	41
4.4	<i>¿Cómo está usted?</i> — “how are you?”	41
4.5	<i>regular</i> and <i>más o menos</i> — the honest “so-so”	42
4.6	Practice — “how are you?”, start to finish	43
5	Farewells	45
5.1	<i>adiós</i> — “goodbye,” or “to God”	45
5.2	<i>hasta</i> — “until,” and Spain’s Arabic centuries	46
5.3	<i>hasta luego</i> — the everyday “see you later”	47
5.4	<i>hasta mañana</i> — “see you tomorrow”	48
5.5	<i>hasta pronto</i> — “see you soon”	48
5.6	Practice — saying goodbye	49
6	The First Verbs	51
6.1	<i>por favor</i> — “please,” i.e. “for a favour”	51
6.2	<i>hablar</i> — “to speak,” and the engine of Spanish sentences	52
6.3	<i>trabajar</i> — “to work,” which once meant <i>torture</i>	54
6.4	<i>estudiar</i> — “to study,” and the eagerness inside it	55
6.5	<i>Hablo español</i> — your first real sentence	55
6.6	Practice — making sentences with <i>-ar</i> verbs	56
7	Eating, Drinking, Living — the <i>-er</i> and <i>-ir</i> Verbs	59
7.1	<i>comer</i> — “to eat,” and the second verb family	59
7.2	<i>vivir</i> — “to live,” and the third family	60
7.3	<i>beber</i> — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours	61
7.4	<i>qué</i> — “what?”, your first question word	62
7.5	<i>dónde</i> — “where?”	63
7.6	Practice — asking real questions	63
8	Numbers, and How Old You Are	65
8.1	<i>uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco</i> — counting to five	65
8.2	<i>seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez</i> — and the calendar’s secret	66
8.3	<i>tener</i> — “to have,” your first irregular verb	67

8.4	<i>¿Cuántos años tienes?</i> — “how old are you?”	68
8.5	Practice — numbers, having, and age	69
9	<i>Ser</i> and <i>Estar</i> — Two Ways to Be	71
9.1	<i>ser</i> — “to be,” the <i>essential</i> kind	71
9.2	<i>ser</i> vs <i>estar</i> — essence vs state	72
9.3	<i>soy de...</i> — saying where you’re from	73
9.4	<i>está en...</i> — saying where something is	74
9.5	Practice — <i>ser</i> or <i>estar</i> ?	75
10	Going, and the Future You Can Already Say	77
10.1	<i>ir</i> — “to go,” stitched from three verbs	77
10.2	<i>voy a</i> + infinitive — the “going-to” future	78
10.3	<i>mí, tu, su</i> — my, your, his/her	79
10.4	Practice — going, planning, and possessing	80
11	Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers	83
11.1	<i>querer</i> — “to want,” and the <i>e→ie</i> crack	83
11.2	<i>poder</i> — “to be able,” and the <i>o→ue</i> crack	84
11.3	<i>e→ie</i> and <i>o→ue</i> — one rule, two vowels	85
11.4	<i>nuestro</i> — “our,” the possessive that agrees fully	86
11.5	Practice — wanting, being able, and the boot	87
12	<i>Hacer, Decir, and the -go Verb Club</i>	89
12.1	<i>hacer</i> — “to do / to make,” and the <i>yo</i> -form that grows a <i>g</i>	89
12.2	<i>decir</i> — “to say,” the verb with two irregularities at once	90
12.3	The <i>-go</i> club — one irregular corner, many verbs	92
12.4	Practice — doing, making, saying	93
13	<i>Poner, Salir, Venir</i> — Completing the <i>-go</i> Club	95
13.1	<i>poner</i> — “to put,” and the club gains a member	95
13.2	<i>salir</i> — “to go out,” from a verb that meant “to leap”	96
13.3	<i>venir</i> — “to come,” cracked <i>and</i> <i>g-grown</i>	98
13.4	The club is complete	99
14	The Preterite — Your First Past Tense	101
14.1	<i>fui</i> — the past arrives, and two verbs become one	101
14.2	<i>hablé</i> — the regular past, built on an accent	102
14.3	Practice — past against present	104

15 Completing the Preterite — Three Families, One Question	105
15.1 <i>comí, viví</i> — two conjugations become one	105
15.2 <i>tuve, hice, estuve</i> — the strong preterites	106
15.3 Practice — three families, one question	107
16 The Imperfect — the Past That Kept Going	109
16.1 <i>hablaba, comía</i> — the past that kept going	109
16.2 <i>era, iba, veía</i> — all three of them	110
16.3 Practice — two pasts, one choice	112
17 The Future and the Conditional — One Weld, Twice	115
17.1 <i>hablaré</i> — the future, welded shut	115
17.2 <i>hablaría</i> — the same weld, one tense over	117
17.3 Practice — ten stems, two tenses	119
18 The Subjunctive — the Mood of the Not-Yet-Real	123
18.1 <i>hable, coma, viva</i> — building the present subjunctive	123
18.2 <i>quiero que...</i> — making the subjunctive appear	127
18.3 Practice — fact or wish?	128

Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

You are *not* meant to read this before starting. Every lesson tells you the one or two sounds you need for its word, and points here if you want more. Look things up as curiosity strikes; otherwise, skip straight to the first chapter and start learning words. This page exists so the sounds are *somewhere* you can find them — never as a wall to climb first.

The five pure vowels

Spanish has exactly five vowel sounds, one per letter, every time — unlike English, which reuses each vowel letter for several sounds.

- **a** — as in *father*. Always.
- **e** — as in *bed*. Always.
- **i** — as the *ee* in *see* (not English *i*). The most common vowel slip for English speakers.
- **o** — as in *note*, short and clean, no *w*-glide.
- **u** — as the *oo* in *food*. Always.

Consonants that differ from English

- **h** — always silent. *hola* is *OH-la*.
- **qu** — a hard *k*, with a **silent u**: *quiero* is *KYEH-ro*.
- **ll** — like English *y*: *llamo* is *YA-mo*.

- **ñ** — the *ny* of *canyon*: *español*.
- **rr** — a rolled *r*; single *r* between vowels is a light tap (*pero* vs. *perro*).
- **j** — a throat-*h*, like Scottish *loch*: *jueves*.
- **c** before *e/i* — soft (*s* in Latin America, *th* in much of Spain): *gracias*.
- **d** between vowels — softens toward *th* in *this*.
- **v** and **b** — essentially identical, a soft *b*.

Stress and written accents

- Ends in a vowel, *n*, or *s* → stress the second-to-last syllable (*ca-SA*).
- Ends in another consonant → stress the last syllable (*ha-BLAR*).
- A written accent (´) overrides both and marks the stress exactly (*ha-BLÓ*, *DÍ-as*); it also separates look-alike words (*qué/que*, *tú/tu*).
- Questions and exclamations open with an inverted mark (¿, ¡) so the intonation is signalled up front.

Chapter 1

Hola and Buenos Días

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

1.1 hola — hello

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] The very first word, and the easiest to say — but there’s already one trap hiding in it, and one small mystery.

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** is **silent**. *hola* is said *OH-la*, never *HOH-la*. The letter is written but makes no sound at all. This is true of every Spanish *h* you’ll ever meet. → pronunciation reference
- **vowel-o, vowel-a** — two pure vowels: *OH*, *AH*. No glide, no drift.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hola — hello / hi.

This one is a genuine mystery, and honesty matters more than a tidy story: *hola*’s origin is **not settled**. It’s an old interjection — a hailing call — and that’s about as far as the evidence firmly goes. You’ll see it confidently linked to English *hello*, or to Arabic *wallāh* (“by God”), or to a nautical shout. Treat all of those as **folk etymology**: plausible-sounding, not established.

In particular, the resemblance to English *hello* is a **false friend**. En-

glish *hello* comes from a Germanic hailing root (*hail*, *holler*, *hollo*) — a completely different family from anything Spanish. The two words sound alike by pure coincidence, not shared ancestry.

Why flag this so hard? Because the whole method of this book is building on real family resemblances between Spanish and English. A *fake* one is worse than none — it teaches a connection your brain then has to unlearn. So: enjoy *hola*, but don't file it next to *hello* in your head. They're strangers who happen to look alike.

Why it's said this way

hola is **informal**. It's the "hi" you'd say to a friend, a kid, a shopkeeper you know. It carries no time of day and no deference — which is exactly why, in more formal or first-meeting situations, Spanish speakers reach past it for *buenos días* and its siblings (the next lessons). Knowing *when not* to use *hola* is as much the lesson as the word itself.

Note the written form: an exclamation gets an **upside-down mark** at the front — *¡hola!* — so you know the tone before you start reading it aloud.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "hola" — *OH-la*, silent h]
- [YOU SAY: "¡hola!" to an imagined friend — light, informal]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Two things to lock in: what sound does the *h* make? (None.) And is *hola* actually related to English *hello*? (No — a coincidence, a false friend.)

1.2 bien — "well," a whole answer in one word

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] You have *hola*. Now the word that carries half of everyday small talk: *bien*. It answers "how are

you,” it agrees to a plan, it stands completely on its own — and it opens a family of English words you already use.

You’ll want to know first

- hola — your first word; *bien* is what you say back when someone asks how you are.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — **ie** is a quick *YEH*: *bien* is said *byen*, one syllable. → reference
- **v-b** — the **b** is soft, halfway to a *v*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bien — “well.” Root: Latin **bene** (“well”). That *bene* is the piece hiding in a shelf of English words, every one about something being *good* or *well*:

- **benefit** — literally “to do **well**” (*bene* + *facere*).
- **benevolent** — “wishing **well**” (*bene* + *volens*).
- **benediction** — “speaking **well**,” a blessing (*bene* + *dicere*).
- **benefactor**, **beneficial**, **benign**.

So *bien* is the Spanish member of the *bene*- family you’ve owned in English your whole life.

Using it on its own. This is the useful part: *bien* is a complete answer.

- “¿Cómo estás?” (how are you?) → “**Bien.**” — “Well.” / “I’m good.” Done.
- As agreement, when someone suggests something → “**Bien.**” — “Okay / fine.”
- Stack it: “**muy bien**” — “very well / very good.”

The adjective sibling: *bueno* / *buena*

bien is an **adverb** — it describes *how* something is done (“you speak *well*”). When you want the **adjective** — to describe a *thing* as “good” — Spanish uses **bueno** (for a masculine word) or **buena** (for a feminine word). These come from Latin **bonus** (“good”), *bene*’s sibling: Latin split the idea of “good” into an adverb (*bene*) and an adjective (*bonus*), and Spanish kept both. The Latin-descended English cousins of *bueno* are *bonus*, *bonanza*, and *bounty*.

English does the exact same split: *well* (adverb) vs. *good* (adjective) — “you did *well*” but “a *good* job.” English’s pair happens to be Germanic, not Latin, so *well/good* aren’t blood cousins of *bien/bueno* — but the *structure* is identical, and that parallel is your handle: **bien = well**, **bueno/buena = good**.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “bien” as the answer to “how are you”]
- [YOU SAY: “muy bien”]
- [YOU SAY: “bueno” then “buena” — the adjective, masculine then feminine]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which is the adverb (“well”) and which is the adjective (“good”)?: (*bien* / *bueno–buena*.) And name an English *bene*- cousin of *bien*. (benefit, benevolent, benediction...)

1.3 el and la — “the,” and the gender it carries

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Before your first noun, meet two of the smallest, most frequent words in Spanish: *el* and *la*. Both mean “the.” Your job here is simply to recognize the pair and connect each form to its label.

You'll want to know first

- bien / bueno — you saw *bueno* change to *buena*; this lesson explains the gender that made it happen.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-e, vowel-a — two clean vowels: *el* (*ehl*), *la* (*lah*). → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el — "the" (masculine). **la** — "the" (feminine). English has one word, "the"; Spanish makes this two-way distinction.

Where they come from. Both are worn-down Latin **demonstratives** — words that meant "**that one (over there)**":

- **el** ← Latin **ille** ("that one," masculine).
- **la** ← Latin **illa** ("that one," feminine).

Over centuries the pointing force faded and the initial *i*- dropped: *ille* → *el*, *illa* → *la*. What began as "that one" softened into a plain "the." The same *ille/illa* spread across the whole family — French *le/la*, Italian *il/la* — every Romance "the" is eroded Latin "that."

The twin thread. Those *same* Latin words, *ille/illa*, also became Spanish **él** ("he") and **ella** ("she"). So the article *el* ("the") and the pronoun *él* ("he") are twins from one Latin parent — told apart only by the accent. (English "the," by contrast, is Germanic and *unrelated* — a shared job, not a shared root.)

What you've built

el and *la* are **articles**: little words that mark "the." Keep them apart from their accented relatives *él* and *ella*, the pronouns "he" and "she." The next micro-lesson explains why Spanish needs two article forms.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "el" then "la" — the two "the"s]

- [YOU SAY: which article goes with a masculine noun? with a feminine one?]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which form is labelled masculine? (*el*.) Which is labelled feminine? (*la*.) Both come from Latin words meaning what? ("That one" — *ille* / *illa*.) What accented twins share their root? (*él* / *ella*.)

1.4 Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind *el* and *la*

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] You know that *el* and *la* both mean "the." Now give their two labels: *el* is masculine; *la* is feminine.

You'll want to know first

- *el* / *la* — the two definite articles.

Grammar Lens: grammatical gender

Every Spanish noun belongs to one of two **grammatical classes**, traditionally called masculine and feminine. This is not a claim about biological sex. It is a matching system: a masculine noun uses *el*; a feminine noun uses *la*.

Latin had masculine, feminine, and neuter classes. Spanish reduced that three-way system to two, with most old neuter nouns joining the masculine class. The word *gender* itself comes through Latin *genus*, "kind" or "class."

You cannot always predict a noun's class from its ending. Learn each new noun with its article, as one small unit: *el* + *noun* or *la* + *noun*.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: the article for a noun labelled masculine]
- [YOU SAY: the article for a noun labelled feminine]
- [YOU SAY: what grammatical gender classifies — nouns, not people]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] How many noun classes did Latin have? (Three.) How many does Spanish keep? (Two.) What should travel with every new noun you learn? (Its article, *el* or *la*.)

1.5 día — your first noun

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] You just learned how Spanish tags gender with *el* / *la*. Now put it to work on your very first noun — *día*, "day."

You'll want to know first

- *el* / *la* — grammatical gender and the two "the"s; *día* is where you apply them.

Sounds you'll need

- **accent-i** — the accent sits on the **í**: *día* is *DEE-a*, two beats. → reference
- **d-soft** — the **d** between vowels is soft, toward the *th* in *this*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el día — "the day." Root: Latin **dies** ("day"). The family fans across English, mostly through French:

- **diary**, **diurnal** ("of the day").
- **journal**, **journey** — French *jour*, "a day" (a *journey* was once "a day's travel").
- **quotidian** ("every-day"), **meridian** ("mid-day"), and **dismal** (*dies mali*, "evil days").

Its two tags: gender and number

You already know gender from the last lesson; here's how *día* wears it. **Gender.** *día* is **masculine** — *el día* — which is a small surprise, because it ends in *-a*, the ending that usually signals feminine. Why the

exception? Because Latin *dies* was masculine, and *día* inherited that gender whole, spelling be damned. (This is exactly why gender must be learned *with* the word, not guessed from the ending — and it’s the first of several “-a-but-masculine” nouns you’ll meet.)

Number. One rule for now: a noun ending in a vowel adds **-s**. *día* → *días* (“days”). (Consonant endings take *-es* — later.)

Grammar Lens: why the gender matters next

Gender isn’t a passive label — it *forces* the words around the noun to match. The very next lesson, *buenos días*, turns *bueno* (“good”) into *buenos* precisely because *día* is masculine and plural. So the gender you just attached to *día* is about to earn its keep.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “el día” — with its masculine “the”]
- [YOU SAY: “días” — plural, vowel + -s]
- [YOU SAY: is *día* masculine or feminine, and why? (masculine — from Latin *dies*, despite the -a)]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which “the” goes with *día*, and why? (*el* — masculine, inherited from Latin *dies*, despite the -a ending.) How do you make it plural? (*días* — vowel + -s.)

1.6 buenos días — assembled from two words you already have

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Now watch two lessons snap together. You have *bueno* (“good,” from the *bien* lesson) and *días* (“days,” from the *día* lesson). Put them side by side and you build the greeting everyone knows — and, for the first time, you’ll know *why it’s shaped the way it is*.

You'll want to know first

- bien / bueno — the adjective *bueno*.
- día — the noun *días*, and that it's masculine.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — **ue** is a quick *WEH*: *bueno* is *BWEH-no*.
- accent-i — *días* keeps its stress on the *í*: *DEE-as*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenos días = **bueno** ("good") + **días** ("days") = literally "**good days**."

But look closely: it's *buenos*, not *bueno*. Why? Because of the one new grammar rule of this lesson.

Grammar Lens: agreement

An adjective in Spanish **agrees** with its noun — it copies the noun's gender and number. *días* is **masculine** (the *día* lesson's flagged exception) and **plural** (the *-s* rule from the *día* lesson). So *bueno* has to become **masculine plural** to match: *bueno* → *buenos*.

The adjective *bueno* has four shapes, and you now understand the machine that picks between them:

- **bueno** — masculine singular (*un buen día* → a good day)
- **buena** — feminine singular
- **buenos** — masculine plural → *buenos días*
- **buenas** — feminine plural (you'll want this one the moment we reach *tardes* and *noches*, which are feminine)

English adjectives never do this — "good" is "good" whether it's one day or a hundred. Spanish makes the adjective echo the noun. That echo is *why* it's *buenos días* and not *bueno días*.

Why it's said this way

So why "good **days**," plural at all? Because *buenos días* is a **fossil** — the worn-down stub of a blessing: "**Buenos días os dé Dios,**" "*may God give you good days.*" You weren't wishing one good morning; you were asking heaven for many good days ahead. The plural is the last bone of that prayer — and it's why *buenos días* feels warm and a little formal, where *hola* is casual. It is, almost literally, a small *benediction* (the *bien* lesson's word). (*A widely-accepted account; exact history debated.*)

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: build it slowly — "bueno" ... "días" ... "buenos días"]
- [YOU SAY: "hola, buenos días" — casual + warm, stacked]
- [YOU SAY: why is it *buenos*, not *bueno*? (out loud, in your own words)]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Two things: why is it *buenos* and not *bueno*? (Agreement — *días* is masculine plural.) And what blessing was *buenos días* shortened from? ("May God give you good days.")

1.7 Practice — hola and buenos días

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] End of the chapter. No new words — just the four you have, turned over until they're automatic.

What you've built

In four short lessons you went from nothing to two full greetings and the first two rules of Spanish grammar:

- **hola** — the casual "hi."
- **bien** — "well/good," a complete answer on its own; and its adjective sibling **bueno** / **buena**.

- **día** → **días** — a noun, and the plural rule (vowel + -s).
- **buenos días** — assembled from *bueno* + *días*, with **agreement** turning *bueno* into *buenos* to match.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s] Say each out loud; don't just read.

- [YOU SAY: greet a friend casually — *hola*]
- [YOU SAY: greet someone warmly in the morning — *buenos días*]
- [YOU SAY: stack them — *hola, buenos días*]
- [YOU SAY: answer "how are you" with one word — *bien*; then *muy bien*]
- [YOU SAY: the four shapes of "good" — *bueno, buena, buenos, buenas* — and for each, is it masculine/feminine, singular/plural?]

[REPEAT x2] Build *buenos días* from scratch, out loud: *bueno* → agree with masculine-plural *días* → *buenos días*. Do it until the "why" feels obvious, not memorized.

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] You can now greet two ways and give a one-word positive answer. The very next question is the one that opens a real conversation: when *someone else* says *buenos días* to you — **what do you say back?** That's the whole next chapter, and it's where these words start turning into an exchange.

Chapter 2

The Rest of the Greetings

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

2.1 tarde — ”afternoon,” and the ”late” hiding inside it

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] You built *buenos días*. The afternoon greeting is coming, but first its key word on its own — *tarde* — and it’s secretly a word you already know from English.

You’ll want to know first

- *buenos días* — you’ll pair *tarde* with *buena* the same way you paired *días* with *bueno*.

Sounds you’ll need

- Regular stress: *TAR-de* — ends in a vowel, so the stress falls on the second-to-last syllable. → reference

la tarde (feminine) — ”afternoon.” Root: Latin **tardus** — which did *not* mean afternoon. It meant ”**slow, late.**” And *that* is the meaning English kept:

- **tardy** — late.
- **retard** — to slow down (literally ”to make late”).

- **tardigrade** — “slow-stepper,” the real name of the little water-bear that plods under a microscope.

How did “late” become “afternoon”? Naturally — the afternoon *is* the late part of the day, the day growing old. Spanish took the Latin word for “late” and let it drift to name the lateness itself. Say *tarde* and you’re calling it “the late hours.”

Its gender: *tarde* is **feminine** — *la tarde*, not *el tarde*. (Contrast *el día* from the last lesson: your first masculine and feminine nouns, side by side.) Learn each noun *with* its *el/la*, because gender isn’t reliably guessable — and it will decide the shape of every word that describes the noun, starting next lesson.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “tarde” — *TAR-de*]
- [YOU SAY: “tarde” then English “tardy” — hear the shared root]
- [YOU SAY: “tardes” — plural, add -s (vowel ending), just like *día* → *días*]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What did Latin *tardus* originally mean, before “afternoon”? (Slow, late — as in *tardy*, *retard*.) And how do you make *tarde* plural? (*tardes* — vowel + -s.)

2.2 buenas tardes — assembled, and now the *feminine* side of agreement

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Same move as *buenos días*: take “good” and “afternoon” and snap them together. But watch the ending — this time it comes out *buenas*, and that difference teaches you the other half of the agreement rule.

You'll want to know first

- bien / bueno — the adjective *bueno* and its four shapes.
- tarde — the noun *tardes*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas tardes = **buena** ("good") + **tardes** ("afternoons") = literally "good afternoons."

Grammar Lens: agreement, the feminine case

Back in *buenos días*, *bueno* became *buenos* — **masculine** plural, because *día* is masculine. Now: **tarde is a feminine noun** (*la tarde*). So *bueno* has to become **feminine** plural to match — *buenas*. Same rule, other gender:

- *días* (masculine, plural) → *buen**os** días*
- *tardes* (feminine, plural) → *buen**as** tardes*

That single vowel — the *o* vs. *a* at the end of *buenos/buenas* — is the adjective reporting the gender of the noun it's attached to. You now control all four shapes in the wild: *bueno*, *buena*, *buenos*, *buenas*.

Why it's said this way

Same fossil blessing as the morning greeting: *buenas tardes* is short for "*Buenas tardes os dé Dios*." One cultural note on timing — *tardes* runs from after the midday meal until it's genuinely dark, which in much of the Spanish-speaking world is late. Spanish follows the daylight, not the clock; there's no fixed "12:00 = afternoon" line.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "buenas tardes" — *BWEH-nas TAR-des*]
- [YOU SAY: "buenos días" then "buenas tardes" — hear the *o* flip to *a*]
- [YOU SAY: why *buenas* and not *buenos*? (out loud, your own words)]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Why is it *buenas tardes* but *buenos días*? (*tarde* is feminine, *día* is masculine — the adjective agrees with each.)

2.3 noche — "night," and a Latin sound-change you can now spot

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] The last time-of-day word before the evening greeting, *noche* — "night" — and it shows off a spelling pattern that will help you decode dozens of Spanish words later.

You'll want to know first

- *tarde* — same build ahead: word first, then *buenas* + it.

Sounds you'll need

- **soft-c** — the **ch** in *noche* is the *ch* of English *church*: *NO-cheh*.
→ reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la noche (feminine) — "night / evening." Root: Latin **nox**, stem **noct-** — which was itself *feminine* in Latin, and *la noche* inherited that gender straight down (just as *el día* inherited its masculine from Latin). That *noct-* runs all through English:

- **nocturnal** — active at night.
- **nocturne** — a piece of night-music.
- **equinox** — *equi* ("equal") + *nox*, the day when night and day are equal length.

A pattern worth banking: Latin *noctem* → Spanish *noche*. The Latin **-ct-** softened into Spanish **-ch-**. This happened again and again: *factum* → *hecho* ("done"), *lactem* → *leche* ("milk"), *octo* → *ocho* ("eight"). Once you know *-ct-* → *-ch-*, you can often guess the Latin root (and its English cousins) behind a Spanish *-ch-* word on sight.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "noche" — *NO-cheh*]
- [YOU SAY: "noche" then "nocturnal" then "equinox"]
- [YOU SAY: "noches" — plural, vowel + -s]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What English word is *equi-* + *noche*'s root? (*Equinox*, "equal night.") And what Latin sound did the *-ch-* in *noche* come from? (*-ct-*, as in *noctem* → *noche*.)

2.4 buenas noches — good evening *and* good night

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] The fourth greeting, assembled the way you now expect — and it has one quirk the others don't: it works both coming and going.

You'll want to know first

- buenas tardes — feminine agreement (*buenas*); *noche* is feminine too, so the same shape applies.
- noche — the noun *noches*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas noches = **buena** ("good") + **noches** ("nights"). *noche* is **feminine** (*la noche*), plural here, so — exactly like *tardes* — the adjective is **buenas**. No new rule; you're now just *fluent* in the agreement you learned two lessons ago: masculine *días* → *buenos*, feminine *tardes/noches* → *buenas*.

Why it's said this way

The same amputated blessing ("*Buenas noches os dé Dios*") — but with a twist. *buenas noches* is both a **greeting** and a **farewell**:

- Arriving at a dinner at 9pm → *buenas noches* ("good evening").

- Leaving that same dinner at midnight → *buenas noches* (“goodnight”).

English splits these into two phrases; Spanish uses one and lets context tell you the direction. The blessing doesn’t care which way you’re going — you’re wishing good hours either way.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “buenas noches” arriving somewhere]
- [YOU SAY: “buenas noches” leaving somewhere]
- [YOU SAY: all four times of day — “buenos días, buenas tardes, buenas noches” — and notice which take *buenos* vs *buenas* and why]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What’s unusual about when you can use *buenas noches*? (Both hello and goodbye.) And why *buenas*, not *buenos*? (*noche* is feminine.)

2.5 Practice — the four greetings

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] You can now greet at any hour of the day. Let’s make the choice — and the grammar behind it — automatic.

What you’ve built

- **hola** — any time, casual.
- **buenos días** — morning (*días* masculine → *buenos*).
- **buenas tardes** — afternoon (*tarde* feminine → *buenas*).
- **buenas noches** — evening *and* goodnight (*noche* feminine → *buenas*).

The one grammar thread running through all of them: **agreement**. The

”good” word copies the gender of the time-of-day word. That’s why it’s *buenos días* but *buenas tardes* and *buenas noches*.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: greet for the actual current time of day, correctly]
- [YOU SAY: all three ”buenos/buenas” greetings in a row; for each, say whether the noun is masculine or feminine and why the ending fits]
- [YOU SAY: ”hola, buenas tardes” — casual + timed, stacked]

[REPEAT x2] Run morning → afternoon → night, out loud, without hesitating on *buenos* vs *buenas*.

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Quick: is it *buenos* or *buenas* noches, and why? (*buenas* — *noche* is feminine.) Next chapter, someone finally greets *you* back — and you learn to say your name and ask for theirs.

Chapter 3

Introducing Yourself

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

3.1 me — your first pronoun, and a *real* English twin

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] A tiny word doing big work. *me* is your first **pronoun** — and unlike *hola*, its English look-alike is the real thing: a true cousin, not a coincidence.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-**e** — one clean syllable, *meh* (the *e* of *bed*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me — "me / myself." Root: Latin **me** (the object form of *ego*, "I"). Here's the satisfying part: English **me** is a **genuine cousin**, not a false friend. Spanish *me* comes from Latin *me*; English *me* comes from Proto-Germanic — but both trace back to the *same* ancient ancestor (the Proto-Indo-European root *me-*, "me"). So do English **my** and **mine**. This is the opposite of the *hola/hello* trap you saw earlier: here the resemblance is real, and you can lean on it hard. Spanish *me* = English *me*, all the way down.

Grammar Lens: what a pronoun is

A **pronoun** is a stand-in word that points to a person or thing without naming them — *I, you, he, me, it*. *me* specifically is an **object** pronoun: it marks the person the action lands on (“call *me*”, “give *me*”). In Spanish it usually sits **right before the verb** — you’ll see it next lesson in *me llamo*, literally “myself I-call.” For now, just hold *me* = “me / myself.”

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: “me” — *meh*]
- [YOU SAY: “me” then English “me”, “my”, “mine” — all one family]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Is Spanish *me* a true cousin of English *me*, or a coincidence like *hola/hello*? (A true cousin — both from the same ancient root.) What part of speech is it? (A pronoun.)

3.2 llamo — “I call,” from a root that shouts

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] The verb inside “my name is.” On its own it means “to call” — and its Latin root literally means *to shout*, which is why it echoes through a whole family of English words.

You’ll want to know first

- me — you’ll bolt *me* onto *llamo* next lesson.

Sounds you’ll need

- ll-y — ll sounds like English y: *llamo* is *YA-mo*, not *LA-mo*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llamo — "I call." The dictionary form (the infinitive) is **llamar**, "to call." Root: Latin **clamare**, "to cry out, to shout." That *clam-* shouts all through English:

- **exclaim**, **exclamation** — *ex-* ("out") + *clamare*: to shout **out**.
- **proclaim**, **proclamation** — *pro-* ("forth"): to call **forth**.
- **acclaim** — *ad-* ("toward"): to shout praise toward.
- **claim**, **reclaim**, **disclaim**; and **clamor**, borrowed whole.

A sound-pattern to bank: Latin *cl-* became Spanish *ll-*. *clamare* → *llamar*. It happened repeatedly: *clavem* → *llave* ("key"), *flamma* → *llama* ("flame"), *plovere* → *llover* ("to rain"). A Spanish word starting *ll-* is very often a Latin *cl-/fl-/pl-* word in disguise — and its English cousin usually kept the original cluster (*clamor*, *flame*, *pluvial*).

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "llamo" — *YA-mo*]
- [YOU SAY: "llamo" then "exclaim", "proclaim", "clamor" — the shouting root]
- [YOU SAY: "llamar" (to call), "llave" (key) — both from Latin *cl-*]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does the root *clamare* mean? (To shout / cry out.) Latin *cl-* becomes which two letters in Spanish? (*ll-* — *clamare* → *llamar*.)

3.3 me llamo — "I call myself"

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Snap the last two lessons together — *me* + *llamo* — and you can introduce yourself. But notice Spanish doesn't say "my name is" at all.

You'll want to know first

- me · llamo

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me llamo = **me** ("myself") + **llamo** ("I call") = literally "**I call myself.**" Then the name: *Me llamo Susana* — "I call myself Susan."

Grammar Lens: reflexive verbs

When the action loops back onto the person doing it — you call *yourself* — the verb is **reflexive**, and Spanish marks it with that little pronoun in front: *me* ("myself"). *llamo* alone is "I call [someone else]"; *me llamo* is "I call **myself**." English can do this ("I call myself Sam") but usually doesn't bother, flattening it to "my name is." Spanish keeps the reflexive loop visible.

This matters because the pronoun **changes with the person**: *me llamo* (I call myself) → *te llamas* (you-informal call yourself) → *se llama* (he/she/you-formal calls himself). You'll meet *te* and *se* in a few lessons; for now, lock in *me llamo* for yourself.

Why it's said this way

Spanish presents your name not as a thing you *have* ("my name is") but as what you *do* — what you call yourself. It's subtly more active, and it's the completely standard, neutral way to introduce yourself.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "me llamo" + your own name]
- [YOU SAY: "hola, me llamo ____" — greeting + introduction]
- [YOU SAY: what does *me llamo* literally mean, word for word?]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Literally, what is *me llamo*? ("I call myself.") What makes it reflexive? (The *me* — the action loops back on you.)

3.4 tú and usted — two words for "you," and why you must choose

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] English has one word for "you." Spanish has two, and picking the wrong one can send the wrong social signal. This lesson gives you both and shows the everyday choice. The remarkable history of *usted* comes next.

The two words

tú — "you," **informal**. For friends, family, children, peers, anyone you're on easy terms with.

Root: Latin **tū**. This is a **true cousin** of English **thou** — the word English used to have for exactly this job, the intimate "you" (*thou/thee/thy*), before it faded out around 400 years ago. Both *tú* and *thou* come straight from the same ancient root (*tu-*). So Spanish still uses, every day, the pronoun English quietly retired.

usted — "you," **formal**. For strangers, elders, officials, customers, anyone you're showing respect or keeping distance with.

Grammar Lens: the choice English lost

Both are **subject pronouns** — the "doer" word, like *yo* ("I"). But they carry a second layer English dropped when *thou* died: **social register**. Choosing *tú* vs. *usted* tells the listener how you see the relationship — close or respectful. English "you" is one-size-fits-all; a Spanish speaker must decide every time.

One structural surprise, because it explains the next lessons: **usted takes *he/she* verb forms**, not the informal "you" forms. That's why "what's your name?" formally is *¿cómo se llama usted?* (the *se llama* you'd use for "he calls himself") and not *te llamas*. The next micro-lesson explains the history behind that third-person pattern.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "tú" — for a close friend]
- [YOU SAY: "usted" — for someone you'd address respectfully]

- [YOU SAY: "tú" then English "thou" — the retired twin]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which is formal, *tú* or *usted*? (*usted*.) What English pronoun is the lost twin of *tú*? (*Thou*.) Which verb pattern does *usted* take? (The same form used with "he" or "she.")

3.5 *vuestra merced* → *usted* — respect compressed into one word

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] You use *usted* for respectful "you," and it takes the same verb form as "he" or "she." That surprising grammar preserves the word's history.

You'll want to know first

- *tú* / *usted* — the informal and formal choices.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

usted wore down from **vuestra merced**, "your grace" or "your mercy." *Vuestra* comes from Latin *vestra*, "your." *Merced* comes from Latin *merces*, *mercedem*, "wages, reward, favor."

The *merc-* root links **mercy**, **mercenary**, **commerce**, **merchant**, and **merchandise**. A respectful title was repeated so often that two words compressed into one pronoun. Its older abbreviation **Vd.** still preserves the *v* of *vuestra*.

Why it's said this way

A title like "your grace" refers to a respected person in the third person. That is why modern *usted* still takes the he/she verb form even while it means "you." The social history remains visible in the grammar.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: the two-word title that became *usted*]

- [YOU SAY: "usted" followed by "mercy" and "merchant" — the *merc-* family]
- [YOU SAY: which verb pattern *usted* takes]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What did *vuestra merced* mean? ("Your grace" or "your mercy.") Why does *usted* take the he/she verb form? (It began as a third-person title.)

3.6 cómo — "how," your first question word

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] To ask someone's name or how they are, you need this word first. *cómo* — "how" — and it carries a little word for "manner" you already own in English.

Sounds you'll need

- **inverted-marks** — Spanish questions open with an upside-down *¿* so you see the question coming: *¿cómo...?*
- **accent-mark** — the accent on **ó** marks the stress *and* flags it as a question word (see below): *CÓ-mo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cómo — "how." Root: Latin **quomodo** — a fused little phrase, *quo modo*, "in what **manner**."

The two halves, and their English cousins:

- *modo* ("manner, measure") → English **mode**, **modal**, **model**, **moderate**, **modify**, **commodity**.
- *quo* ("in what") is the Latin question-stem **qu-** — the seed of almost every Spanish question word (see the family below).

How *quomodo* became *cómo* — the wearing-down. Spanish didn't borrow *cómo* ready-made; it *eroded* out of *quomodo* over centuries of everyday speech. The final *-do* fell off and the middle collapsed:

quomodo → *quomo* → **como**

The *qu-* (a *kw* sound) flattened to a plain *k* (written *c* before *o*). What's left is *quomodo* worn smooth — the way a pebble loses its edges in a river. The same erosion gave Italian *come*, Portuguese *como*, French *comme*. The accent in *cómo* is the one late addition: Spanish stamps it on to mark the question (vs. accent-less *como*, "like / as").

Grammar Lens: the accent that marks a question

Watch the accent mark do real work. **cómo** (with the accent) = "how?", the question word. **como** (no accent) = "like / as," or "I eat." Same letters, and the written accent is the *only* thing telling you it's a question:

- ¿**Cómo** estás? — "How are you?"
- **Como** tú. — "Like you." / Yo **como**. — "I eat."

English has no such marker — it relies on word order and context. Spanish puts a visible flag on the question word. Every question word you'll learn (*qué, dónde, cuándo, quién...*) carries this accent for the same reason.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "¿cómo?" — with question intonation]
- [YOU SAY: "cómo" then English "mode", "model" — the *modo* root]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Walk the erosion: *quomodo* → ? → *cómo* (*quomo* → *como*, then the question-accent). What changes when the accent disappears? (*como* is no longer the question word "how.")

3.7 The *qu-* question family — one ancient pattern, many clues

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] You traced *cómo* back to Latin *quomodo*. Focus now on its first piece, *qu-*, without trying to use a whole set of new question words yet.

You'll want to know first

- cómo — "how," from Latin *quomodo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin used a recurring *qu-* stem in questions. Spanish preserves that family, although centuries of sound change gave the modern forms different shapes:

| Spanish clue | ← Latin | future meaning | |—|—|—| | *qué* | *quid* | what
 | | *quién* | *quem* | who | | *cuál* | *qualis* | which | | *cuándo* | *quando* | when
 | | *cuánto* | *quantus* | how much | | **cómo** | *quomodo* | how |

These are previews, not vocabulary to produce today. For now, use the family only as an etymological clue: a question form beginning *qu-* or *cu-* may continue the same Latin pattern. *Dónde*, "where," is an exception from Latin *de unde*, "from where."

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: the Latin source of *cómo*]
- [YOU SAY: the recurring Latin question stem]
- [YOU SAY: whether the table is today's production list or a preview]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which old stem connects *qué*, *quién*, *cuándo*, and *cómo*? (*qu-*.) Which word in the preview is the exception? (*Dónde*.)

3.8 se llama — the reflexive that fits *usted*

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] You can say *me llamo* ("I call myself").

To ask someone *else* their name — especially formally, with *usted* — you need the version that loops back on *them*: *se llama*.

You'll want to know first

- me llamo — the reflexive "I call myself."
- tú / usted — and the key fact that *usted* takes *he/she* verb forms.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

se llama = **se** ("himself / herself / yourself-formal") + **llama** ("calls"). So *se llama* = "he/she calls himself," or — because *usted* uses third-person forms — "**you** (formal) call yourself."

se — the reflexive pronoun for the third person (and for *usted*). Root: Latin **sē** ("himself, herself, itself"). That same *se-* — carrying the sense of "self / apart / aside" — is bolted onto a shelf of English words:

- **secede** — *se* + *cedere* ("go apart").
- **seclude**, **segregate** ("apart from the flock"), **separate**.
- **seduce** — *se* + *ducere* ("lead aside").
- **secure** — *se* + *cura* ("free from care"), **secret** ("set apart").

Every one is something turned in on itself or set apart — the same idea as a reflexive looping the action back on the doer.

Grammar Lens: the reflexive pronoun changes with the person

The verb *llamar* stays, but the little reflexive word in front shifts to match *who* is doing the calling:

- **me** llamo — *I* call myself
- **te** llamas — *you* (informal, *tú*) call yourself
- **se** llama — *he / she / you* (formal, *usted*) calls himself/yourself

Three persons, three pronouns: *me / te / se*. That *se* is exactly why the formal "what's your name?" is *¿cómo se llama usted?* — *usted*, born from "your grace," politely takes the *he/she* shape.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "se llama" — *seh YA-ma*]
- [YOU SAY: the set — "me llamo, te llamas, se llama"]

- [YOU SAY: "se" then "secede", "seclude", "separate" — the set-apart root]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which reflexive goes with *usted* — *te* or *se*? (*se* — because *usted* takes third-person forms.) What's the "self/apart" root inside *secede* and *separate*? (Latin *se-*.)

3.9 ¿cómo se llama usted? — assembling the question, and answering it

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Everything you built this chapter clicks into one sentence: how to ask a stranger their name, and how to answer back. This is your first real two-way exchange.

You'll want to know first

- cómo · se llama · usted

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo se llama usted? = *cómo* ("how") + *se llama* ("do you-formal call yourself") + *usted* ("you," formal).

Literally: **"How do you call yourself?"** Spanish asks *how*, not *what*, for a name — you're asking by what name a person goes, the manner they're called.

The informal version, for a friend, swaps the reflexive and drops the formal pronoun: **¿Cómo te llamas?** (*te llamas*, from *tú*). Same question, two registers — exactly the *tú/usted* choice from earlier, now live in a real sentence:

- To a stranger, an elder, a customer → *¿Cómo se llama usted?*
- To a friend, a child, a peer → *¿Cómo te llamas?*

How to answer

You already have the answer from the *me llamo* lesson: **Me llamo** ____.

— *¿Cómo se llama usted?* — **Me llamo David.** *¿Y usted?*

(*¿Y usted?* — “And you?” — bounces the same question back; *y* = “and,” a whole lesson’s worth of its own soon, but usable now.)

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: ask a stranger their name — *¿cómo se llama usted?*]
- [YOU SAY: ask a friend the same — *¿cómo te llamas?*]
- [YOU SAY: the whole mini-exchange — ask, then answer with *me llamo* ____]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Formal vs. informal “what’s your name”? (*¿Cómo se llama usted?* / *¿Cómo te llamas?*) Does Spanish literally ask “what” or “how” is your name? (“How” — *cómo*.)

3.10 mucho — “much,” and a sound-change you’ve already seen

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] One more word before “pleased to meet you.” *mucho* — “much, a lot” — and it hides the same Latin-to-Spanish sound trick you spotted in *noche*.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — the **ch** is the *ch* of *church*: *MOO-cho*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mucho — “much, a lot.” Root: Latin **multus** (“much, many”). The English cousins keep the original *-lt-*:

- **multiple**, **multitude**, **multiply**, **multi-purpose**, **multimedia**.

The sound-change, again: Latin *multum* → Spanish *mucho*. The Latin **-lt-** softened into Spanish **-ch-** — the very same move as *noctem* → *noche* (*-ct-* → *-ch-*, as in the *noche* lesson). Spanish has a habit of melting these consonant clusters into *ch*. So a Spanish *-ch-* word very

often points back to a Latin *-ct-* or *-lt-* root — and the English cousin usually preserves it (*nocturnal*, *multiple*).

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "mucho" — *MOO-cho*]
- [YOU SAY: "mucho" then "multiple", "multitude" — the *mult-* family]
- [YOU SAY: "noche" and "mucho" — two words, same *-ch-* from a melted Latin cluster]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] *mucho* comes from Latin *multus* — what English words keep the *-lt-*? (*multiple*, *multitude*, *multiply*.) What Latin cluster melted into the *-ch-*? (*-lt-*, like *-ct-* did in *noche*.)

3.11 gusto → mucho gusto — "much pleasure"

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] The line you say when you shake someone's hand. First the noun *gusto*, then snap *mucho* onto it, and you've got it.

You'll want to know first

- *mucho* — "much," about to modify *gusto*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el gusto (masculine) — "taste; pleasure, liking." Root: Latin **gustus** ("a tasting, a taste"). The English cousins:

- **gustatory** — to do with the sense of taste.
- **disgust** — *dis-* ("not, opposite") + *gust*: literally "**distaste**."
- **gusto** — borrowed whole into English, meaning zest, relish, enjoyment.

False friend to flag: a *gust* of wind is **not** related — that one's from Old Norse *gustr*. Same spelling, different root. Resemblance isn't proof.

mucho gusto = *mucho* ("much") + *gusto* ("pleasure") = literally "**much pleasure**" — short for "it's a great pleasure [to meet you]." *gusto* is masculine (*el gusto*), and *mucho* is in its plain masculine form to match it: another quiet piece of the agreement you've been building.

Why it's said this way

Spanish greets a new acquaintance by naming the *pleasure* of it — "much pleasure" — where English names the *person* ("pleased to meet **you**"). There's a stock reply that volleys it back: "**El gusto es mío**" — "the pleasure is mine."

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: "gusto" then "gusto" (English), "disgust", "gustatory"]
- [YOU SAY: "mucho gusto" — on meeting someone]
- [YOU SAY: the reply — "el gusto es mío"]

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] What does *mucho gusto* literally mean? ("Much pleasure.") Is *el gusto* masculine or feminine? (Masculine.) And the English cousin of *gusto* built from *dis-*? (*Disgust* — "distaste.")

3.12 Practice — introducing yourself

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Ten lessons of atoms now assemble into a real conversation. No new words — just the exchange, run both formally and informally until the *tú* / *usted* choice is automatic.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

- Buenos días. Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo se llama usted?**
- Me llamo David. **Mucho gusto.** — El gusto es mío.

Informal (a friend, a peer): only two words change, and they're the ones that carry the whole social difference:

- ¡Hola! Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo te llamas?** — Me llamo David. Mucho gusto.

What you've built

- **me llamo** — introduce yourself ("I call myself").
- **tú / usted** — the informal vs. formal "you," and *why* (the retired *thou*; *usted* from "your grace").
- **¿cómo te llamas? / ¿cómo se llama usted?** — ask a name, in either register, the pronoun (*te / se*) tracking the choice.
- **mucho gusto** — "much pleasure," pleased to meet you.

Guided Practice

[PAUSE 1s]

- [YOU SAY: the full *formal* exchange, both parts]
- [YOU SAY: the same exchange *informally* — catch yourself on *se llama* → *te llamas*]
- [YOU SAY: for a police officer, then your best friend — which "you" for each, and why?]

[REPEAT x2] Run the formal version start to finish without stopping.

Wrap-up recall

[PAUSE 3s] Which two words change between the formal and informal introduction? (*se llama usted* → *te llamas*.) Next chapter: they answer your "*¿cómo está usted?*" — "how are you?" — and you learn

to say how you're doing.

Chapter 4

How Are You?

Now the conversation moves: you thank someone, you wave the thanks away, and you ask how they are — a question that turns on one of Spanish’s most famous features, its *two* verbs for “to be.” *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C04-*.md.*

4.1 *gracias* — “thank you,” a whole English family

Sounds you’ll need

vowel-a — the clean *ah* of *father*, twice.

r-tap — a single flicked *r* (not the English one, and not yet the rolled *rr*): the tongue taps once, like the middle of American *butter*.

ci — a soft *s* in Latin America (*GRAH-syahs*) and a soft *th* in most of Spain (*GRAH-thyahs*). Either is correct — pick one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gracias is the plural of *gracia* (“grace, favour”) ← Latin *grātia*, *favour freely given*. Saying *gracias* literally offers someone “graces,” good will in return for theirs.

The family: **grace**, **gracious**, **graceful** (the direct borrowings); **grateful**, **gratitude** (being *full of grātia*); **gratis**, **gratuity** (something given as a favour — for free, or a tip); **congratulate** (“to wish grace *together with* someone”).

The whole Romance family keeps *grātia*: Italian *grazie*, French *grâces*, Portuguese *graças*.

So *gracias* is not a word to memorize cold: it is **grace**, made plural and handed to another person.

4.2 *de nada* — “you’re welcome,” or “it was nothing”

Sounds you’ll need

d-soft — the *d* in *nada* is soft, almost the *th* of *this* (*NAH-thah*), not a hard English *d*. Spanish *d* between vowels always softens.

vowel-a — three clean *ah* sounds: *deh NAH-thah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de (“of / from”) ← Latin *dē* — the same *de-* hiding in English **depart**, **deduct**, **descend**.

nada (“nothing”) ← Latin (*rēs*) *nāta*, “(a thing) *born*,” from *nāscī* (“to be born”) → **native**, **nature**, **natal**, **renaissance** (“re-birth”). Latin speakers said *nōn est rēs nāta*, “there is not a born thing” — not a single thing that ever came into being — and over centuries the emphatic *nāta* wore down until the word for “born thing” became the word for “nothing” itself.

French did the identical trick with *rien* (“nothing”), which is Latin *rem*, “a thing.” Two languages, same move: the word for *thing* collapses into the word for *nothing*.

So the reply *de nada* literally says “of [a] born-thing” → “of nothing at all” — you are waving the favour off as no trouble, the same move English makes with “it’s nothing” or “no problem.”

Grammar Lens

gracias → *de nada* is a fixed **adjacency pair**: one turn expects the other. Learn them as a unit, the way English glues “thank you” → “you’re welcome.”

4.3 *estar* — “to be,” the *standing* kind

Sounds you’ll need

st-no-e — Spanish never starts a word with a bare *st-*; it props it up with an *e*: *es-TAR*. (That reflex is why Spanish speakers say *e-Spain*, *e-student* — the same *e* that Latin *stare* grew to become *estar*.)

r-tap — the final *r* is one soft tap: *es-TAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estar ← Latin *stāre*, “to stand” — exactly the right picture for the *temporary* be-verb: how you are *standing* at this moment (well, tired, here, there), not what you permanently *are*.

The stā-/sta- family: **stay**, **stand**, **stance**, **station**, **stable**, **stationary** — to stand or stay put; **state**, **status**, **statue**, **estate** — a way of *standing* (your state = how you stand); **constant**, **circumstance**, **substance** — “standing with / around / under.”

So *¿cómo estás?* is, at the root, “how are you *standing*?” — a snapshot of right now.

Grammar Lens

Spanish has **two** verbs for “to be.” **ser** ← Latin *esse* (“to be”) carries permanent identity: *soy David*, “I am David.” **estar** ← Latin *stāre* (“to stand”) carries temporary state and location: *estoy bien*, “I am well (now)”; *estoy aquí*, “I am here.”

Rule of thumb: how you *feel* and *where* you are → *estar*; who you *are* → *ser*. “How are you?” is about your current state, so it always takes *estar*.

You need only two forms this chapter: *estás* (“you are,” informal *tú*) and *está* (“you are,” formal *usted*; also “he/she is”).

4.4 *¿Cómo está usted?* — “how are you?”

Everything in this chapter now snaps together. Two pieces come from Chapter 3: **cómo** (“how”) ← Latin *quōmodo*, “in what manner” — the *qu-* question family with *qué*, *quién*, *cuándo*; and the **usted** / **tú** choice — *usted* worn

down from *vuestra merced*, “your grace,” and *tú* the old intimate “thou.” The third piece is the *estar* you just met.

cómo (“how / in what manner”) + *está* (“you are,” the *usted*/he-she form of *estar* — state, not identity) + *usted* (the formal “you”) = literally “in what manner are you standing?”

Grammar Lens

Two registers, and only the verb ending and the pronoun change — exactly the *se llama* / *te llamas* split from the last chapter.

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer): ¿Cómo está usted?

Informal (a friend, a peer, a child): ¿Cómo estás?

Why it’s said this way

Note the opening ¿. Spanish opens a question with an upside-down mark so you know the melody is coming *before* you start reading aloud — the sentence tells you how to say it from its first character. (A dedicated writing lesson takes that mark apart.)

4.5 *regular* and *más o menos* — the honest “so-so”

You asked ¿cómo estás? Now you can answer three ways: great, middling, or a wave of the hand. From Chapter 1 you have **bien** (“well”) ← Latin *bene*, the *bene-* of **benefit** and **benevolent** — so *estoy bien* is “I’m well.” Here are the answers for when you are not quite *bien*, because nobody is *bien* every day.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

regular ← Latin *rēgula*, a *straight rod* a builder used to check a line — the **ruler**. So *regular* is “on the rule, on the average line” → middling.

That rod is everywhere in English: **rule**, **ruler**, **regulate**, **regular**, **regiment**, and even **rail** (a straight rod). All the same straight stick.

más (“more”) ← Latin *magis* → **major**, **master**, **maximum**. **menos** (“less”) ← Latin *minus* — the very word English borrowed for **minus**, **minor**, **minimum**, **minuscule**. So *más o menos* is literally “more or less,” root for root the exact phrase English uses for the same shrug.

Why it’s said this way

regular as an answer to “how are you?” is a famous false-friend trap: here it does *not* mean English “regular / normal / usual.” It means **so-so, average, not great.**

Grammar Lens

A small, complete answer set for *¿cómo estás?*: (*muy*) *bien* = “(very) well” · *regular* = “so-so” · *más o menos* = “more or less / meh.”

4.6 Practice — “how are you?”, start to finish

No new words. This chapter’s atoms — *gracias*, *de nada*, *estar*, *¿cómo está?*, *regular* — now assemble into a real exchange, picking up right where the Chapter 3 introduction left off.

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

- *Buenos días. ¿Cómo está usted?*
- *Bien, gracias. ¿Y usted?*
- *Más o menos.*
- [*replying to a thanks, later in the chat*] *De nada.*

Informal (a friend, a peer) — only the verb and the pronoun change:

- *¡Hola! ¿Cómo estás?*
- *Regular. ¿Y tú?*
- *Bien, gracias.*

The one new glue word is *¿y usted?* / *¿y tú?* — “and you?” (*y* = “and,” from Latin *et*). It bounces the question back.

What you built: *gracias*, thank you (← *grātia*, “grace”) · *de nada*, you’re welcome (← “of a born-thing” → “of nothing”) · *estar*, the temporary to-be (← *stāre*, “to stand”), against *ser* for identity · *¿cómo está usted?* / *¿cómo estás?*, formal and informal · *bien* / *regular* / *más o menos*, well / so-so / more-or-less. Two words swap between the registers: *está* → *estás*, and *usted* → *tú*. Next chapter: farewells — *hasta luego*, *hasta mañana*, *adiós*.

Chapter 5

Farewells

Every conversation needs a door out. Spanish gives you two kinds: a blessing worn smooth by centuries, and a small family of “until...” phrases built on a word Spain took from Arabic. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C05-*.md.*

5.1 *adiós* — “goodbye,” or “to God”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

adiós (“goodbye”) is *a* + *Dios* = “**to God**” — the front half of an old blessing, *a Dios te encomiendo*, “I commend you to God,” said to someone setting off when a journey was dangerous and you left them in God’s keeping.

Dios (“God”) ← Latin *Deus* → **deity**, **divine**, *adieu*; and, through Greek *Zeus* from the same root, the whole sky-god family.

Every Romance sister kept the same prayer: Spanish *adiós*, French *adieu* (à *Dieu*), Italian *addio*, Portuguese *adeus* — all four literally “to God.”

And English is doing it too, quietly: **goodbye** is a crushed-down “God be with ye.” So *adiós* and *goodbye* are, at heart, the same sentence — a blessing for the road.

Sounds you’ll need

adiós = *ah-DYOHS*. The *-íos* is one glide, not two syllables: *ee* + *ohs* run together into *dyohs*. The written accent on the *ó* tells you the stress lands at the end.

Grammar Lens

adiós is a *final* goodbye. It leans toward a longer parting — you won’t see the person soon, or the day is over. For “see you later” or “see you tomorrow,” Spanish reaches instead for *hasta* ..., which is what the rest of this chapter builds — and *hasta* has a surprising origin.

5.2 *hasta* — “until,” and Spain’s Arabic centuries**The word, taken apart — and its English cousins**

hasta (“until, up to”) ← Arabic *hattā*, “until, up to.” Not Latin — Arabic.

Why there was Arabic in Spain: from **711 CE**, Muslim armies ruled much of the Iberian Peninsula — *al-Andalus* — and Arabic was the language of government, science, and poetry there for centuries, until 1492. Spanish absorbed roughly **four thousand** Arabic words in that time — more of its vocabulary than from any source except Latin itself.

Spotting the loans: most are nouns, and a huge number carry the frozen Arabic article *al-* (“the”) fused onto the front — *almohada* (pillow), *alcázar* (fortress), *alcalde* (mayor), *alfombra* (rug), *aduana* (customs), *álgebra*, *alcohol*; also *azúcar* (sugar), *aceite* (oil), *naranja* (orange).

But *hasta* is rare and special: it is a **function word** — a preposition, part of the grammatical skeleton. Languages borrow nouns easily and grammar words almost never, so an Arabic preposition surviving in everyday Spanish shows how deep, how *intimate*, those centuries of contact were. (Its Latin rivals *ad* “to” and *usque* “up to” simply lost.) You say a piece of al-Andalus every time you say goodbye.

And *hasta* is not quite alone. **Ojalá** (“would that...”) is also a function word, from Andalusí Arabic *law shā’ Allāh*, “**if God should will**” — the *Allāh* is still sitting in its second half. It is arguably the stronger case: where *hasta* is a preposition, *ojalá* reaches into the grammar and forces the verb after it into a whole different **mood**. Chapter 18 puts it to work.

Sounds you’ll need

Spanish **h** is **always silent**: *hasta* = *AHS-tah*, with no breath on the *h* at all. Stress the front.

Grammar Lens

hasta marks the **end point** of something, in space or in time: *hasta aquí* (“up to here”), *hasta las tres* (“until three o’clock”), and *hasta luego* / *mañana* / *pronto* (“until later / tomorrow / soon”) — the farewells that fill the rest of this chapter.

5.3 *hasta luego* — the everyday “see you later”

This is the goodbye you will actually use most: friendly, casual, open-ended. *hasta* (“until”) + *luego* (“later”) = “until later” → “see you later.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

luego (“later / then / soon”) ← Latin *loco*, “at the place, at that point.” The idea slid from *place* → *point in time* → “then, next, soon.”

Its English cousins all stayed about place: **local**, **locus**, **location**, **locate**, **allocate**. Spanish moved *loco* from *where* to *when*.

Two histories in three syllables: *hasta luego* fuses an **Arabic** word and a **Latin** word — the two great layers of Spanish, shaking hands as you leave.

Sounds you’ll need

luego = *LWEH-goh*: the *ue* is a *w*-glide, so *lu-* becomes *lweh-*. The whole phrase: *AHS-tah LWEH-goh*.

Grammar Lens

hasta + a time word is Spanish’s whole toolkit of soft goodbyes: *hasta luego* (“until later”) is the default “see you”; *hasta mañana* (“until tomorrow”) is for leaving for the day; *hasta pronto* (“until soon”) is for when you expect to meet again shortly. You build the other two in the next two sections.

5.4 *hasta mañana* — “see you tomorrow”

Leaving for the day? *hasta* (“until”) + *mañana* (“tomorrow”) = “until tomorrow.” And it brings back a letter of its own: the ñ.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mañana means “tomorrow” and “morning” — one word for both — from Latin (*hōra*) *maneana*, “the **early** hour” (from *māne*, “in the morning”). The logic: the next early hour you will see is *tomorrow morning*, so *mañana* came to mean both **morning** and **tomorrow**. *por la mañana* = “in the morning”; *hasta mañana* = “until tomorrow.”

The ñ, in the wild. The ñ is a frozen *nn* — a scribe’s shorthand for a doubled *n*, the tilde being a tiny second *n* written on top. *mañana* comes from Latin *maneana*, whose *n* + *ea* palatalized (softened) into that single ñ sound. The tilde is a little historical fossil sitting in the middle of “tomorrow.”

Sounds you’ll need

mañana = mah-NYAH-nah. The ñ is the squished *ny* of “canyon.” Three soft *ah*’s, with the stress in the middle.

Grammar Lens

mañana means “morning” or “tomorrow,” and the sentence tells you which — Spanish lets context do the disambiguating where English uses two separate words. Paired with *hasta*, it is always **tomorrow**: *hasta mañana*, “until tomorrow.”

5.5 *hasta pronto* — “see you soon”

The last of the trio: *hasta* (“until”) + *pronto* (“soon”) = “until soon,” for when you genuinely expect to meet again shortly.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pronto (“soon / quickly / ready”) ← Latin *promptus*, “brought forth, ready at hand” (from *prōmere*, “to bring out”). Something *prompt* is brought out without delay — so *pronto* slid to “soon.”

Its English twin is hiding in plain sight: prompt (on time; to bring

out a response), **prompter**, **promptly**, and the computer **prompt** — the cursor sitting “ready” for input.

Italian borrowed *pronto* too: it is what Italians say when they pick up the phone — “*Pronto!*” = “Ready!”

Sounds you’ll need

hasta pronto = *AHS-tah PRON-toh* — a clean *pr* cluster and a pure *o* (not the English *oh-w* glide).

Grammar Lens

The *hasta ...* trio, sharpest to vaguest in time: *hasta pronto* (soon — you’ll meet again shortly) → *hasta luego* (later — the neutral default “see you”) → *hasta mañana* (tomorrow — you’re parting for the day). And *adiós* sits outside the trio, for the long or final goodbye.

5.6 Practice — saying goodbye

No new words. The choice among these four is really one question: **when will you meet again?** Parting for good or for a long time → *Adiós*. Expecting to meet again shortly → *Hasta pronto*. Just “see you,” the neutral default → *Hasta luego*. Leaving for the day → *Hasta mañana*.

Everything from Chapters 1–5, in one conversation:

- *¡Hola! Buenos días. Me llamo Ana. ¿Cómo se llama usted?*
- *Me llamo Luis. Mucho gusto.*
- *¿Cómo está usted?*
- *Bien, gracias. ¿Y usted?*
- *Muy bien. Bueno... hasta mañana, Luis.*
- *Hasta mañana, Ana. ¡Adiós!*

Why it’s said this way

Spanish closes a conversation by naming *the next meeting*, not the parting itself. English says “bye” and stops; Spanish says “until later,” “until tomorrow,” “until soon” — each one a small promise about the future. Even *adiós*, the one goodbye that does *not* promise a next time, still hands the person over to someone: “to God.”

What you built this chapter: *adiós*, the plain or final goodbye (“to God,” twin of *goodbye*); *hasta*, “until,” Spain’s everyday Arabic word; and *hasta luego* / *mañana* / *pronto*, see you later / tomorrow / soon, each an Arabic + Latin handshake. You can now open *and* close a conversation in Spanish. Next chapter: *por favor*, and the courtesies that partner *gracias*.

Chapter 6

The First Verbs

The chapter where the course stops handing you phrases and starts handing you *rules*. One courtesy word completes the politeness set; then three verbs snap into a single template — the regular *-ar* present tense — and you build a sentence nobody gave you pre-assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C06-*.md.*

6.1 *por favor* — “please,” i.e. “for a favour”

Sounds you’ll need

One soft tapped **r** in *por* and in *favor*: the tongue flicks the ridge behind the teeth once, as in the middle of English *butter*.

Spanish **v** and **b** sound *identical* — both a soft *b*. So *favor* is *fah-BOR*: it looks like English *favour* and its *v* is pronounced like the *b* you hear in *harbour*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

por (“for / through / by”) ← Latin *prō* (“for, on behalf of”) — the same *pro-* in English **pronoun**, **propose**, **protect**.

favor (“a favour, goodwill”) ← Latin *favēre*, “to be favourable to, to support.” English borrowed the very word: **favour**, **favorite**, **favorable**, **favouritism**.

por + favor = literally “for a favour” — [*do this*] as a kindness to me. The neighbours build “please” out of very different pictures:

Language	“Please”	Literally
Spanish	<i>por favor</i>	“for a favour”
Italian	<i>per favore</i>	“for a favour” (the exact twin)
French	<i>s’il vous plaît</i>	“if it pleases you”
German	<i>bitte</i>	“I ask / I pray”

Grammar Lens

The courtesy set is now complete, and it is only three pieces: *por favor* for asking, *gracias* for receiving, *de nada* for replying. *Un café, por favor* → *¡Gracias!* → *De nada*. That loop covers nearly every small transaction you will have.

6.2 *hablar* — “to speak,” and the engine of Spanish sentences

Sounds you’ll need

The **h** is completely silent: *hablar* is *ah-BLAR*, never *hah-BLAR*. Spanish *h* never makes a sound at all.

The **b** is soft, halfway to a *v*: *hablo* is *AH-bloh*. The final **r** of *hablar* is a single tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hablar (“to speak, to talk”) ← Latin *fābulārī*, “to chat, to tell tales” ← *fābula*, “a story.” To *speak*, in Spanish, is at root to *tell stories*. That *fābula* is thoroughly English: **fable**, **fabulous** (“story-like”), **confabulate**, **ineffable** (“un-speak-able”).

The f→h sound-law: Latin *f*- became Spanish *h*- across the whole language. Put the *f* back and the cousin appears.

That one law decodes hundreds of words:

Spanish (h-)	Latin (f-)	English cousin
<i>hablar</i> (to speak)	<i>fābulārī</i>	fable
<i>harina</i> (flour)	<i>farīna</i>	farina, farinaceous
<i>hacer</i> (to do)	<i>facere</i>	fact, factory
<i>hijo</i> (son)	<i>filius</i>	filial, affiliate
<i>hierro</i> (iron)	<i>ferrum</i>	ferrous, ferric

Grammar Lens

A **verb** is the action word of a sentence, and its plain dictionary form — “to speak” — is the **infinitive**. Spanish infinitives come in three families named for their last two letters: *-ar*, *-er*, *-ir*. *hablar* is *-ar*, the largest family by far.

To **conjugate** it — to reshape it for who is doing the action — you drop the *-ar* and add an ending. English barely does this (*I speak*, but *he speaks*); Spanish does it for every person, and the ending carries so much information that the word for “I” becomes unnecessary. *Hablo español* = “I speak Spanish”: no *yo* needed, because the *-o* already says “I.”

Person	Ending	<i>hablar</i> →	Meaning
<i>yo</i> (I)	<i>-o</i>	<i>hablo</i>	I speak
<i>tú</i> (you, informal)	<i>-as</i>	<i>hablas</i>	you speak
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	<i>-a</i>	<i>habla</i>	he/she speaks; you (formal) speak
<i>nosotros</i> (we)	<i>-amos</i>	<i>hablamos</i>	we speak
<i>ellos / ustedes</i>	<i>-an</i>	<i>hablan</i>	they / you-all speak

This same template fits *every* regular *-ar* verb. The next two sections add no new grammar at all — they just snap into it.

6.3 *trabajar* — “to work,” which once meant *torture*

Sounds you’ll need

The **j** (the *jota*) is a raspy *h* scraped from the back of the throat: *trabajar* is *tra-ba-HAR*. It is the same sound as the *j* of *jamón*.

The **rs** are single taps and the **b** is soft.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

trabajar (“to work”) ← Vulgar Latin *tripaliāre*, “to torture” ← *tripalium*, a Roman instrument of torture made of *three stakes*: *tri-* (“three”) + *pālus* (“stake”), the root of English **pale** (a fence stake) and **impale**. English took the same word down a parallel road: **travail** (painful, laborious effort — and the pains of childbirth) and, astonishingly, **travel**. Journeying was once such an ordeal that the word for *toil* became the word for *taking a trip*.

Why it’s said this way

The chain of meaning is grimly logical: *torture* → *torment*, *suffering* → *hard toil* → plain *work*. So *Trabajo mucho* (“I work a lot”) is, at the root, “I am tortured a lot” — and every time you *travel*, you are etymologically being tortured too.

Drop the *-ar*, add the ending — identical to *hablar*:

Person	<i>trabajar</i> →	Meaning
<i>yo</i>	<i>trabajo</i>	I work
<i>tú</i>	<i>trabajas</i>	you work
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	<i>trabaja</i>	he/she works; you (formal) work

Notice that you learned nothing new — that is exactly the point. One template, every *-ar* verb.

6.4 *estudiar* — “to study,” and the eagerness inside it

Sounds you’ll need

Spanish props up an initial *st-* with an *e*: it is *es-tudiar*, never *stu-*. The same reflex gives *estar*, *España*, *escuela*.

The *-iar* ending glides into one syllable: *es-too-DYAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estudiar (“to study”) ← Latin *studēre*, “to be eager, to apply oneself zealously.” A *studium* was *zeal*, *enthusiasm*, *devotion* — only later “study.”

That root is everywhere in English: a **student** is literally “one who is eager”; **studio**, **studious**, and **study** are the place, the trait, and the act. Italian *studio* and the musical *studio* keep the “devoted practice” sense.

So *Estudio español* is, at heart, “I throw myself eagerly at Spanish” — a nicer picture than mere schoolwork.

Person	<i>estudiar</i> →	Meaning
<i>yo</i>	<i>estudio</i>	I study
<i>tú</i>	<i>estudias</i>	you study
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	<i>estudia</i>	he/she studies; you (formal) study

Three verbs, one pattern: *hablo*, *trabajo*, *estudio*. You now hold the whole regular *-ar* present tense.

6.5 *Hablo español* — your first real sentence

Sounds you’ll need

ñ is the *ny* of *canyon* — a doubled *n* that Spanish scribes squeezed under a tilde. *español* is *es-pa-NYOL*, and the *h* of *hablo* stays silent: *AH-bloh es-pa-NYOL*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

español (“Spanish”; also “a Spaniard”) ← *Hispania*, the Roman name for the Iberian peninsula. The path *Hispania* → *hispaniolus* → *español* wore the word down — and the *-ni-* of *hispaniolus* is precisely where the **ñ** comes from. English **Spanish**, **Hispanic**, and **Hispaniola** are all the same root; *Hispania* itself may go back through Latin to a **Phoenician** name for the coast, “land of hyraxes (rabbits).”

Snap two things you already own together: *hablo* (“I speak,” from *hablar*) + *español* (“Spanish”) = *Hablo español*. A complete, grammatical Spanish sentence, assembled by you.

Grammar Lens

Notice what is *not* there.

No *yo*. The *-o* of *hablo* already means “I,” so the subject pronoun is dropped. *Yo hablo español* is correct too, but it adds emphasis — “I speak Spanish (whatever the others do).”

No “the” and no “a.” Names of languages stand bare in this position: *hablo español*, not *hablo el español*.

Now swap the pieces and watch the template generate: *Estudio español* (“I study Spanish”) · *Trabajo mucho* (“I work a lot”) · *¿Hablas español?* (“Do you speak Spanish?” — just raise the pitch, and open with the *¿* from the writing chapter).

6.6 Practice — making sentences with *-ar* verbs

Run each verb through *yo* → *tú* → *él/ella* until it is automatic:

Infinitive	<i>yo</i> (–o)	<i>tú</i> (–as)	<i>él/ella/usted</i> (–a)
<i>hablar</i>	<i>hablo</i>	<i>hablas</i>	<i>habla</i>
<i>trabajar</i>	<i>trabajo</i>	<i>trabajas</i>	<i>trabaja</i>
<i>estudiar</i>	<i>estudio</i>	<i>estudias</i>	<i>estudia</i>

Say something real:

- *¿Hablas español?* — *Sí, hablo un poco.*
- *¿Trabajas o estudias?* — *Estudio español.*
- *Un café, por favor.* — *¡Gracias!* — *De nada.*

What you built this chapter: *por favor* (“for a favour”), completing *gracias* / *de nada* / *por favor*; the regular -ar present tense — drop -ar, add -o / -as / -a (then -amos / -an); the three verbs *hablar* (← *fābula*, fable, by the f→h law), *trabajar* (← *tripalium*, torture → travail, travel), *estudiar* (← *studēre*, eagerness → student); and *Hablo español*, your first self-assembled sentence, with no *yo* and no article.

You can now generate sentences rather than recite them. Next chapter: the -er and -ir verbs, and questions with *qué* and *dónde*.

Chapter 7

Eating, Drinking, Living — the *-er* and *-ir* Verbs

Spanish has exactly three verb families, and you have already met one of them. This chapter hands you the other two — *-er* and *-ir* — which turn out to be almost the same as each other. Then it gives you two question words, so that for the first time you can *ask* something and understand the answer. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C07-*.md.*

7.1 *comer* — “to eat,” and the second verb family

Sounds you’ll need

The *c* before *o* is a hard *k*, and the final *r* is one soft tap of the tongue: *comer* = *ko-MER*, with the stress on the second syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comer (“to eat”) ← Latin *comedere*, “to eat up” — *com-* (an intensifier, “completely”) + *edere*, “to eat.”

That *edere* is the twin of English **eat**: both descend from the same ancient root, the Latin and Germanic branches of one family.

The English relatives: **edible** (“fit to be eaten”), **comestible** (a fancy word for food, straight from *comedere*), and **eat** itself.

Grammar Lens

A **verb** is the action word of a sentence, and Spanish changes its ending to show *who* is doing the action. The *-er* family works exactly like the

-ar family with the *a*'s swapped for *e*'s. Chop the -er off *comer* to get the stem *com-*, then add:

person	-ar was	-er is	<i>comer</i> →
<i>yo</i> (I)	-o	-o	<i>como</i> (I eat)
<i>tú</i> (you, informal)	-as	-es	<i>comes</i> (you eat)
<i>él / ella / usted</i> (<i>nosotros</i> , we)	-a	-e	<i>come</i> (he/she eats)
(<i>ellos / ustedes</i> , they/you all)	-amos	-emos	<i>comemos</i>
	-an	-en	<i>comen</i>

So the *yo* form is identical (-o), and *tú/él* simply trade *a* for *e*: *hablas / habla* → *comes / come*. If you know -ar, you already know ninety percent of -er.

Why it's said this way

Watch this small trap: *como* means “I eat” and “like / as” (*como tú*, “like you”) and, once it puts on an accent, *cómo* = “how?” Same four letters, three jobs — the accent and the surrounding words sort them out.

7.2 *vivir* — “to live,” and the third family

Sounds you'll need

The Spanish *v* is pronounced as a soft *b*, so *vivir* sounds roughly like *bee-BEER*. The final *r* is again a single tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vivir (“to live”) ← Latin *vīvere*, “to live” — one of the most alive roots in English.

vivid (“full of life”), **survive** (← *super-vīvere*, “to live beyond”), **revive** (“live again”), **vivacious**, **convivial** (“living together,” so sociable), **viva!**, **vivarium**.

And the noun beside it, Latin *vīta* (“life”), gives English **vital** and **vi-tamin**.

Grammar Lens

Here is the punchline of the whole system: in the present tense, *-ir* is almost identical to *-er*. Set the three families side by side in the singular:

person	<i>-ar</i> (<i>hablar</i>)	<i>-er</i> (<i>comer</i>)	<i>-ir</i> (<i>vivir</i>)
<i>yo</i>	<i>hablo</i>	<i>como</i>	<i>vivo</i>
<i>tú</i>	<i>hablas</i>	<i>comes</i>	<i>vives</i>
<i>él / ella</i>	<i>habla</i>	<i>come</i>	<i>vive</i>

Look closely: *-er* and *-ir* are *identical* in the singular (*-o* / *-es* / *-e*). They part company only in the “we” and “you all” forms — *comemos* / *coméis* against *vivimos* / *vivís*. So learning *-ir* costs you almost nothing. Three families, three vowels, one idea. You can now conjugate the present tense of virtually any regular Spanish verb.

7.3 *beber* — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours**Sounds you’ll need**

Both *b*’s are the soft Spanish *b*, the same sound as the Spanish *v*: *be-BER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

beber (“to drink”) ← Latin *bibere*, “to drink” — a thirsty little root that soaked into English.

beverage (a drink, by way of Old French *bevrage*, from *bibere*), **imbibe** (“to drink in”: *in-* + *bibere*), **bibulous** (fond of drinking), and **bib**, the cloth that catches the drips. Even **beer**’s cousins hover nearby.

Grammar Lens

There is no new grammar here, and that is exactly the point. *beber* is a regular *-er* verb, so it takes the endings you already own:

person	form	meaning
<i>yo</i>	<i>bebo</i>	I drink
<i>tú</i>	<i>bebes</i>	you drink
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	<i>bebe</i>	he/she drinks; you (formal) drink

Nothing new to learn — you are simply reusing the machine. Which means you can now say: *Como pan y bebo agua.* (“I eat bread and drink water.”) Two verbs, two nouns, one sentence you built yourself.

7.4 *qué* — “what?”, your first question word

Sounds you’ll need

qu is a plain hard *k* and the *u* is silent, so *qué* = *keh*. The accent on the *é* marks this as the *question* word: *qué* = “what?”, while *que* without the accent = “that.” Question words wear the accent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

qué (“what?”) ← Latin *quid*, “what” — the neuter form of *quis*, “who.” It is a small function word with a few learned English descendants:

quiddity — the “what-ness,” the essence of a thing; **quid pro quo** — “*what* for *what*,” this for that.

The family it heads in Spanish: *qué* (what), *quién* (who), *cuál* (which) — Latin’s *qu-* question words. Latin *qu-* and English *wh-* are ancient cousins, which is why the two languages share the same questioning instinct.

Grammar Lens

Put *qué* in front of a verb, wrap the whole thing in the pair of Spanish question marks, and you have a real question:

¿*Qué comes?* — “What are you eating? / What do you eat?”

¿*Qué bebes?* — “What are you drinking?”

The opening ¿ warns the reader that a question is coming, and the accent on *qué* marks which word is doing the asking. Answer with the verb you already conjugate: *Como pan.* (“I eat bread.”)

7.5 *dónde* — “where?”

Sounds you’ll need

The middle *d* is soft, close to the *th* of English “this”: *DON-deh*. As with *qué*, the accent on the *ó* marks the question word — *dónde* = “where?”, while *donde* without the accent means “where” as a connector, as in “the place *where* I live.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dónde (“where?”) ← Latin *de unde*, literally “from whence.” *unde* meant “from where”; Spanish glued *de* onto the front and wore the pair down to *dónde*.

English once had the matching set **whence** / **where** / **whither** — “from where / at where / to where.” Spanish keeps that flavour alive: *de dónde* (“from where”), *dónde* (“where”), *adónde* (“to where”).

Grammar Lens

Two question words plus the verbs you own = real conversation:

¿*Dónde vives?* — “Where do you live?” → *Vivo en Madrid.*

¿*Dónde trabajas?* — “Where do you work?”

¿*Qué estudias?* — “What do you study?”

Notice the little *en* (“in”) in the answer, from Latin *in* — your first preposition, slipping in exactly where you need it. You are now trading real questions and answers, not reciting fixed phrases.

Why it’s said this way

¿*Dónde vives?* is the single most common getting-to-know-you question in Spanish, and the answer opens a door: the city you name tells your listener which Spanish you speak, which food you eat, and often how to place you. Pair it with ¿*Y tú?* (“and you?”) and the conversation runs itself.

7.6 Practice — asking real questions

You now have all three verb families *and* two question words. This is where it becomes a conversation: you can ask and answer, not just recite. Conjugate

yo → *tú* → *él/ella* and feel how little differs:

family	verb	<i>yo · tú · él/ella</i>
-ar	<i>hablar</i>	<i>hablo · hablas · habla</i>
-er	<i>comer</i>	<i>como · comes · come</i>
-ir	<i>vivir</i>	<i>vivo · vives · vive</i>

The endings: -ar takes -o / -as / -a; -er and -ir both take -o / -es / -e, identical in the singular. Master these and you conjugate almost any regular verb.

- *¿Dónde vives? — Vivo en Sevilla. ¿Y tú?*
- *Vivo en México. ¿Qué estudias?*
- *Estudio español. ¿Qué comes?*
- *Como una tapa y bebo un café. ¿Algo más?*
- *Un agua, por favor.*

What you built this chapter: *comer* and *beber* (the -er family) and *vivir* (the -ir family), with the singular endings -o / -es / -e; *qué* (from *quid*) and *dónde* (from *de unde*), each wearing its accent and opening with *¿*; and real questions — *¿Qué comes?*, *¿Dónde vives?*, *¿Dónde trabajas?* — answered with the first preposition, *en*. Try chaining a whole café moment: greet, order with *por favor*, ask and answer, then *gracias* and *adiós*. Next chapter: numbers — *uno, dos, tres* — and telling someone your age.

Chapter 8

Numbers, and How Old You Are

Numbers are the most reused words in any language, and Spanish counts almost exactly the way Latin did — which means each one planted an English word you can lean on. Then one irregular verb, *tener* (“to have”), turns those numbers into your age: in Spanish you don’t *be* twenty, you *have* twenty years. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C08-*.md.*

8.1 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco* — counting to five

Sounds you’ll need

cuatro = *KWA-tro* — the *cu-* is a *kw* glide, not two separate vowels. The *r* in *tres* and *cuatro* is a soft tap of the tongue against the ridge behind the upper teeth — close to the *tt* in the American pronunciation of “butter,” not an English *r*.

Spanish	← Latin	English cousins
uno (1)	<i>ūnus</i>	unit, union, unique, unanimous, universe
dos (2)	<i>duo</i>	duo, dual, duet, double, duplex
tres (3)	<i>trēs</i>	trio, triple, trinity, trident, triangle
cuatro (4)	<i>quattuor</i>	quart, quarter, quadrant, square
cinco (5)	<i>quīnque</i>	quintet, quintessence, quintuplet

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Pattern: Latin *qu-* softens on its way into Spanish — *quattuor* → *cuatro* (*qu-* → *cu-*), *quīnque* → *cinco* (*qu-* → *c-*).

So *cinco* and **quintet** are the same number wearing different clothes. *uno* also stands behind English **one** and **a/an**. Count the family on your fingers: **unit**, **duo**, **trio**, **quart**, **quint**.

Grammar Lens

uno shrinks when it stands in front of a noun: **un** (masculine) / **una** (feminine). A **noun** is a word for a thing or a person; Spanish sorts every noun into one of two classes, *masculine* or *feminine*, and the words in front of it must match.

These shrunken forms do double duty: Spanish makes no distinction between “one” and “a/an.” *un café* is both “a coffee” and “one coffee”; *una cerveza*, “a beer / one beer.” The other numbers (*dos*, *tres*, *cuatro*, *cinco*) never change shape.

8.2 *seis*, *siete*, *ocho*, *nueve*, *diez* — and the calendar’s secret

Sounds you’ll need

siete = *SYE-teh* and **nueve** = *NWE-veh*. Those *ie* and *ue* glides — two vowels said in one smooth motion — are a Spanish signature; you will meet them again in almost every irregular verb.

Spanish	← Latin	English cousins
seis (6)	<i>sex</i>	sextet , sextant , semester (six months)
siete (7)	<i>septem</i>	September (the 7th month), septet , septuagenarian
ocho (8)	<i>octō</i>	October (8th), octopus , octave , octagon
nueve (9)	<i>novem</i>	November (9th), novena
diez (10)	<i>decem</i>	December (10th), decimal , decade , dime , decimate

Why it’s said this way

Why are the “7th–10th” months numbered 7–10 when they sit at positions 9–12 on the calendar? Because the old **Roman year began in March** — so *September* really was the seventh month.

Julius Caesar and Augustus later inserted **July** and **August**, named for themselves, shoving the counting-months out of place. The Latin numbers stayed put anyway. Every time you say *December*, you are saying Roman “**ten**.”

Grammar Lens

Past ten, Spanish **fuses** “ten and X” into a single word:

diez y seis (“ten and six”) → *dieciséis* (16); *diez y siete* → *diecisiete* (17), and onward to 19.

English built its own teens the identical way: *six + ten = sixteen*. *Dieciséis* and **sixteen** are the same two numbers glued together in the same order.

8.3 tener — “to have,” your first irregular verb

A **verb** is an action or state word (“speak,” “eat,” “have”), and a **regular** verb changes its ending by a fixed, predictable recipe. *hablo* (“I speak”), *como* (“I eat”), *vivo* (“I live”) are all tidy that way. *tener* is your first **irregular** verb, and it breaks the rules in the two ways Spanish verbs most often do.

Sounds you’ll need

tener = *te-NER*, with the stress on the second syllable. When the stem cracks open you get the *ie* glide again: **tienes** = *TYE-nés*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tener (“to have”) ← Latin *tenēre*, “to hold, to keep, to grasp.” Having is, at root, *holding*.

The bare root: **tenant** (one who *holds* land), **tenure**, **tenacious** (*hold-ing* on), **tenable**, **tenet** (a *held* belief).

With prefixes: **contain** (“hold together”), **retain** (“hold back”), **maintain** (“hold in hand”), **sustain** (“hold up”), **detain**, **obtain**.

Grammar Lens

tener misbehaves in exactly the two classic Spanish ways. First, the *yo* (“I”) form is odd: not *teno* but ***tengo***, with a *-g-* appearing from nowhere. A handful of very common verbs do this (*hago*, *pongo*, *salgo*, *vengo*).

Second, the stem vowel breaks $e \rightarrow ie$ in the stressed forms — a **stem-changer**.

Person	Form	Note
<i>yo</i> (I)	tengo	the <i>-go</i> form
<i>tú</i> (you, informal)	tienes	$e \rightarrow ie$
<i>él / ella / usted</i> (he, she, you-formal)	tiene	$e \rightarrow ie$
<i>nosotros</i> (we)	tenemos	back to plain <i>e</i> — unstressed
<i>ellos / ustedes</i> (they, you-plural)	tienen	$e \rightarrow ie$

Notice that *tenemos* keeps the plain *e*: the vowel only cracks to *ie* when the stress falls on it. Sketch the changed forms on the table and they trace a boot shape around the untouched *nosotros* — which is why this is called the **boot** pattern. It is the single most common irregularity in Spanish, and *tener* is your model for it.

8.4 ¿Cuántos años tienes? — “how old are you?”

With *tener* and your numbers you can now ask and give an **age** — and Spanish does it in a way English does not.

¿Cuántos años tienes? = “How old are you?”
literally: “How many years do you have?”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cuántos (“how many”) ← Latin *quantus*, “how much, how great” → **quantity**, **quantum**, **quantify**. It belongs to the *qu-* question family: *qué*, *cómo*, *dónde*, *cuántos*.

años (“years”) ← Latin *annus* — and there is the *ñ* again, born from the doubled *nn* of *annus*. *annus* also gives English **annual**, **anniversary**, **biennial**.

tienes (“you have”) — the *tener* you just learned.

Grammar Lens

cuántos **agrees** with the noun it counts: because *años* is masculine and plural, the question word takes the matching masculine plural ending, *cuántos años*. Spanish makes the words around a noun echo its gender and number; English leaves them alone.

Why it’s said this way

Age is had, not been. Spanish counts age with *tener* (“have”), never with *ser/estar* (“be”).

— *¿Cuántos años tienes?* — *Tengo veinte años.* (“I have twenty years.”)

Saying *soy veinte* (“I am twenty”) is simply wrong. You possess your years; you do not equal them. French and Italian agree — *j’ai vingt ans*, *ho vent’anni*, both “I have.”

Say it as *KWAN-tos AN-yos TYE-nes*, and answer *Tengo ... años* with your own number.

8.5 Practice — numbers, having, and age

Two new powers this chapter: you can **count**, and you can talk about what you **have** — including your years. Drill both until they are automatic.

Count up: uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco, seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez.

tener, all forms: tengo · tienes · tiene · tenemos · tienen.

— *Hola. ¿Cómo te llamas?* — *Me llamo Ana. ¿Y cuántos años tienes?*

— *Tengo veintiuno. ¿Y tú?*

— *Tengo diecinueve.*

— *Un café, por favor. ¿Cuánto es?* — *Dos euros.*

What you have built: the **numbers 1–10** (← *ūnus ... decem*; *cinco*/**quintet**, *diez*/**December**) and the **teen fusion** *diez y seis* → *dieciséis* (= **sixteen**); **tener**, “to have” (← *tenēre* “hold”; **tenant**, **retain**, **contain**), your first irregular, stem-changing verb, with its *-go* form *tengo* and its *e* → *ie* crack;

and *¿Cuántos años tienes?*, age given with *tener* rather than “be,” where *años* $\leftarrow$ *annus* brings back the *ñ*.

Next chapter: *ser* versus *estar* head-on — the two “to be” verbs, sorted for good.

Chapter 9

Ser and *Estar* — Two Ways to Be

Spanish has *two* verbs where English has one. This chapter finally meets the second one, *ser*, and settles the famous question of when to use which — a choice that is not arbitrary at all, but written into the two Latin roots. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C09-*.md.*

9.1 *ser* — “to be,” the *essential* kind

Back in Chapter 4 you met **estar** — the *temporary* to-be (← *stāre*, “to stand”): how you *are right now*, and *where*. It always came with a promise: Spanish has **two** be-verbs, and here is the other. **ser** is the *permanent* one — what a thing *essentially is*. It is also your second irregular verb, and its irregularity is spectacular.

Sounds you’ll need

r-tap — *ser* ends in one soft tap of the tongue: *SER*.

no propping e here — unlike *es-tar*, *ser* already starts with its own vowel, so nothing has to be propped up in front of it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ser ← Latin *esse*, “to be” — the plainest, oldest verb there is. (Vulgar Latin actually rebuilt the infinitive as **essere*, and even folded in a second verb, *sedēre* “to sit,” which is why a few forms look like they wandered in from elsewhere.)

The es- family runs deep into English: essence, essential, entity, and — all the way down — **is, am, are**. This is the ancient PIE root **h₁es-*, “to be.” When you say *es*, you are saying a cousin of English

is.

With prefixes: **present** (← *prae-esse*, “to be before / at hand”), **absent** (← *ab-esse*, “to be away”), **interest** (← *inter-esse*, “to be between”).

So *ser* is not just a word to memorize — it is the same ancient “be” that English carries in *is* / *am* / *are*.

Grammar Lens

ser is **suppletive**: its forms come from *different* Latin words fused into one verb, so you cannot derive them from the infinitive. You simply learn them as a set.

person	form	Latin source
yo	soy	<i>sum</i> (“I am”); the <i>-y</i> is the same odd tail as in <i>estoy</i> / <i>voy</i> / <i>doy</i>
tú	eres	<i>eris</i> (“you will be”) — a future form drafted into the present
él / ella / usted	es	<i>est</i> — literally cognate with English <i>is</i>
nosotros	somos	<i>sumus</i>
ellos / ustedes	son	<i>sunt</i> — cognate with the plural English <i>are</i>

Say them as a set: *soy · eres · es · somos · son*. Notice how *es* and *son* sit right next to English *is* and Latin *sunt* — you half-knew this verb before you started.

9.2 *ser* vs *estar* — essence vs state

This is the lesson every Spanish learner waits for and dreads. Two verbs, one English word (“to be”). But the choice is not arbitrary — it is written into the **etymology** of each verb. Get the roots, and the rule follows.

verb	root	picture	used for
ser	<i>esse</i> → essence	what a thing <i>is</i>	identity, origin, profession, nationality, material, the time
estar	<i>stāre</i> → stand, state	how a thing <i>stands</i> now	mood, condition, location, the temporary

The mnemonic writes itself: **ser** = **essence**, **estar** = **estado** — *estado* being the Spanish for “state,” the very word *estar* built. Permanent, defining truth → *ser*. Passing state or where-you-are → *estar*.

Soy alto. — “I am tall.” (a defining trait → *ser*)

Estoy cansado. — “I am tired.” (a passing state → *estar*)

Es médico. — “She is a doctor.” (identity → *ser*)

Está en casa. — “She is at home.” (location → *estar*, always)

Grammar Lens

Here is the proof that the split is *real*, not decoration. Swap *ser* for *estar* on the **same adjective** and the meaning changes — because *essence* and *state* are genuinely different claims.

with ser (essence)	with estar (state)
<i>es aburrido</i> — “he <i>is</i> boring” (his nature)	<i>está aburrido</i> — “he <i>is</i> bored” (right now)
<i>es listo</i> — “she <i>is</i> clever” (a trait)	<i>está lista</i> — “she <i>is</i> ready” (this moment)
<i>es rico</i> — “he <i>is</i> rich” (wealth)	<i>está rico</i> — “it <i>tastes</i> delicious” (this dish)
<i>es verde</i> — “it <i>is</i> green” (its colour)	<i>está verde</i> — “it <i>is</i> <i>unripe</i> ” (its state)

Why it's said this way

Same adjective, two verbs, two worlds. A boring person *is* (*ser*) boring; a bored person merely *stands* (*estar*) bored today. This is why Spanish keeps two verbs where English merged them into one — it can say in one word things English needs extra words for. Say it twice and let it stick: “*ser* = who/what it is; *estar* = how/where it is *right now*.”

9.3 *soy de...* — saying where you're from

You have *ser*. Now aim it. **Where you are from** and **what you do** are treated as *essence* in Spanish — they define you — so both take *ser*, not *estar*. This is where the split starts paying rent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de (“from / of”) ← Latin *dē* (“down from, about”). It is one of the most common words in Spanish, and its English children are everywhere as

the prefix **de-**: **deduct**, **depart**, **descend**, **describe** — all carrying the “from / down-from” of *dē*.

Origin is a permanent fact about you, so the pattern is *ser* + *de* + place:

Soy de México. — “I’m from Mexico.”
Eres de España. — “You’re from Spain.”
Es de Colombia. — “She’s from Colombia.”

And to ask it, Spanish fronts the *de*: *¿De dónde eres?* — literally “From where are-you?” (*dónde*, “where,” you met in Chapter 7; here it rides with *de* to mean *from where*.)

Grammar Lens

Note that it is *eres*, not *estás* — even though *dónde* usually pairs with *estar* for location. Origin is not *where you are standing*; it is *what you are*. Essence → *ser*.

Because profession and nationality also define you, they are *ser* too — and they take **no article**:

Soy profesor. — “I’m a teacher.”
Soy español. — “I’m Spanish.”
Somos estudiantes. — “We’re students.”

Why it’s said this way

Spanish drops the “a” with a bare profession: *soy profesor*, never *soy un profesor*, unless you add something to it. The naked noun is enough — you are not *a* teacher among many, you simply *are* teacher. (And there is *español* again, from Chapter 6, back through Latin *Hispania*.)

9.4 *está en...* — saying where something is

The mirror image of the last lesson. Origin was *ser* (essence). But **location** — where a thing physically *stands* right now — is the home turf of *estar* (← *stāre*, “to stand”). The root tells you: to be *located* is to *stand* somewhere.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en (“in / on / at”) ← Latin *in* — and it *is* English **in**, barely changed in two thousand years. Latin *in* → Spanish *en*, English *in*; the same word runs through **interior**, **include**, **invade**.

One Spanish word covers three English prepositions: *en casa* = “at home,” *en la mesa* = “on the table,” *en Madrid* = “in Madrid.” And location is always *estar* — never *ser*, with no exceptions for physical place:

Estoy en casa. — “I’m at home.”

Estás en Madrid. — “You’re in Madrid.”

Está en la mesa. — “It’s on the table.”

To ask it, pair *dónde* with *estar*: *¿Dónde estás?* — “Where are you?”
Answer: *Estoy en casa.*

Grammar Lens

Put the two questions side by side and the whole chapter snaps into focus.

question	verb	why
<i>¿De dónde eres?</i> — “Where are you <i>from</i> ?”	<i>ser</i> (<i>eres</i>)	origin = essence
<i>¿Dónde estás?</i> — “Where are you <i>at</i> ?”	<i>estar</i> (<i>estás</i>)	location = state

Same word *dónde*, two different be-verbs — and each is locked in by meaning. *From* where → what you *are* (*ser*). *At* where → where you *stand* (*estar*). Even a permanent-seeming place stays *estar*: *Madrid está en España* — cities do not move, but *being located* is still *estar*.

9.5 Practice — *ser* or *estar*?

The whole chapter comes down to one reflex: **essence** → **ser**, **state** → **estar**. Drill it until you do not have to think. Say each form aloud, and for every sentence name *why* the verb is the one it is.

ser (essence)	estar (state)
soy	estoy
eres	estás
es	está
somos	estamos
son	están

ser is suppletive (*sum, eris, est, sumus, sunt*); *estar* carries the -oy tail in *estoy*, the same tail as *soy, voy, doy*.

Sort these — say “ser” or “estar,” then the reason:

“I’m a doctor.” → *ser* (soy médico — *identity*)

“I’m tired.” → *estar* (estoy cansado — *passing state*)

“She’s from Peru.” → *ser* (es de Perú — *origin*)

“The keys are on the table.” → *estar* (están en la mesa — *location*)

“We’re students.” → *ser* (somos estudiantes — *identity*)

“You’re at home.” → *estar* (estás en casa — *location*)

Then the minimal pairs, where the meaning flips with the verb: *es aburrido* (“is boring”) vs *está aburrido* (“is bored”) · *es listo* (“is clever”) vs *está listo* (“is ready”) · *es rico* (“is rich”) vs *está rico* (“tastes delicious”) · *es verde* (“is green”) vs *está verde* (“is unripe”).

Now say something real:

— *Hola. ¿De dónde eres?* — *Soy de México. ¿Y tú?*

— *Soy de España. Soy profesor. ¿Dónde estás ahora?*

— *Estoy en casa. Estoy un poco cansado, pero bien.*

Two verbs, one conversation: *soy de / soy profesor* (essence → *ser*), *estoy en casa / estoy cansado* (state → *estar*).

What you built this chapter: *ser*, the essence to-be (← *esse* → essence / present; suppletive *soy · eres · es · somos · son*, cousins of English *is / am / are*), completing the pair begun with *estar* in Chapter 4 · the *ser/estar* split read straight off the roots — *essence* (*ser*) vs *estado/standing* (*estar*) — with minimal pairs that flip meaning · *soy de...* (origin → *ser*; *de* ← *dē*) and *está en...* (location → *estar*; *en* ← *in*), plus the twin questions *¿De dónde eres?* and *¿Dónde estás?* Next chapter: the near future — *ir a* + infinitive, “going to...” — and possessives.

Chapter 10

Going, and the Future You Can Already Say

Three new powers: you can *go* somewhere, you can talk about the *future*, and you can say *whose* something is. The future comes almost free — Spanish builds tomorrow out of the verb “to go,” exactly as English does. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C10-*.md.*

10.1 *ir* — “to go,” stitched from three verbs

Sounds you’ll need

vowel-i — the infinitive *ir* is just *eer*: two letters, one of the shortest verbs in Spanish.

diphthong-oy — *voy* sounds like *boy* (a *b/v* sound + “oy”), sharing the *-oy* tail of *soy*, *estoy*, *doy*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ir (“to go”) is not one verb but *three* Latin verbs collapsed into a single Spanish one.

The infinitive *ir* ← Latin *īre*, “to go” → English **exit** (*ex-īre*, “to go out”), **transit**, **ambition**.

The present *voy*, *vas*, *va*, *vamos*, *van* ← a different Latin verb, *vādere*, “to advance, to rush” → English **invade**, **evade**, **wade**.

The past *fui* (which comes later) ← Latin *esse/fuī*, “to be” — the same *fu-* that supplies the past of *ser*.

So the present tense of “to go” does not come from the word *ir* at all. It comes from *vādere*:

Person	Form	Note
yo	<i>voy</i>	the <i>-oy</i> , like <i>soy</i> , <i>estoy</i> , <i>doy</i>
tú	<i>vas</i>	
él / ella / usted	<i>va</i>	
nosotros	<i>vamos</i>	this is also “let’s go!”
ellos / ustedes	<i>van</i>	

Grammar Lens

When a single verb draws its forms from more than one original verb, linguists call it **suppletion**. English does exactly this: *go* in the present, but *went* in the past — and *went* was borrowed from a completely different old verb, *wend*. Spanish plays the same trick, only it does it *inside* one tense: the infinitive from one Latin verb, the present from another, the past from a third.

Grammar Lens

Pointing *ir* at a destination. Add *a* (“to” ← Latin *ad*) and then the place:

Voy a Madrid. — “I’m going to Madrid.”

Vamos a casa. — “We’re going home / Let’s go home.”

When *a* meets the masculine article *el*, the two contract into **al**: *voy al café*, “I’m going to the café.”

10.2 *voy a* + infinitive — the “going-to” future

Here is a gift. Spanish builds its everyday future *exactly* the way English does. English says “I’m **going to** speak”; Spanish says ***voy a hablar***. Same verb, same metaphor — so you get a whole tense for almost nothing.

An **infinitive** is the dictionary form of a verb, the naming form: in English “to speak,” in Spanish *hablar* (“to speak”), *comer* (“to eat”), *vivir* (“to live”). Take the present of *ir*, add *a*, then add any infinitive at all:

Person	Spanish	English
yo	<i>voy a hablar</i>	“I’m going to speak”
tú	<i>vas a comer</i>	“you’re going to eat”
él / ella / usted	<i>va a estudiar</i>	“she’s going to study”
nosotros	<i>vamos a vivir</i>	“we’re going to live”
ellos / ustedes	<i>van a trabajar</i>	“they’re going to work”

Only *ir* changes. The second verb stays a bare infinitive and is never conjugated — just as English keeps “to speak” unchanged after “going to.”

Grammar Lens

Why “go” becomes “future.” It is one of the most natural metaphors in human language: *movement toward* something becomes *time approaching* it. If you are *going to* a place, you have not arrived — the place is ahead of you — so “going to (do something)” comes to mean “about to, soon.” French makes the same move (*je vais parler*, “I’m going to speak”), English makes it, Spanish makes it: three languages, one picture. Spanish even keeps the little *a* (“to” ← Latin *ad*) that English swallows in speech, where “going to” becomes “gonna.”

10.3 *mi, tu, su* — my, your, his/her

To say *whose* something is, Spanish puts a small word in front of the noun: *mi casa* (“my house”), *tu café* (“your coffee”). These are called **possessives**, and they come straight from Latin.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mi (“my”) ← Latin *meus* — a genuine cousin of English **my** and **mine** (and **me**).

tu (“your,” informal — what belongs to a *tú*) ← Latin *tuus* — the cousin of English **thy** and **thine**, the old intimate “your” that English retired.

su (“his / her / its / your-formal / their”) ← Latin *suus* — the *su-* that survives in the borrowed phrase *sui generis*, “of its own kind.”

Two things to notice.

Grammar Lens

***tu* versus *tú*.** The possessive **tu** (“your”) has *no* accent; the pronoun **tú** (“you”) does. This is the same device you have seen elsewhere in the writing system — *el* versus *él*, *si* versus *sí*. The accent here is called the *tilde diacrítica*: it does no work for pronunciation, it only separates two look-alike words on the page.

Why it’s said this way

***su* does a great deal of work.** One little word covers *his*, *her*, *its*, *your-formal* and *their* all at once, and context is normally enough to tell you which is meant. *Su casa* can be “his house,” “her house,” “your house” (to an *usted*), or “their house.” When it is genuinely unclear, Spanish spells it out afterwards: *de él* (“of him”), *de ella* (“of her”), and so on.

Grammar Lens

They agree in number, not gender. Unlike most Spanish modifiers, *mi* / *tu* / *su* do *not* change for masculine or feminine: *mi casa* (feminine) and *mi café* (masculine) both take plain *mi*. They change only for **number** — add *-s* when the noun is plural.

Singular	Plural	English
<i>mi libro</i>	<i>mis libros</i>	“my book → my books”
<i>tu casa</i>	<i>tus casas</i>	“your house → your houses”
<i>su amigo</i>	<i>sus amigos</i>	“his friend → his friends”

(*nuestro* / *nuestra*, “our” ← Latin *noster*, is the one possessive that *does* flex for gender. You will meet it in full later.)

10.4 Practice — going, planning, and possessing

No new words. Drill the irregular *ir* until *voy*, *vas*, *va*, *vamos*, *van* is automatic, because the whole future rides on it.

- ***ir*, present:** *voy* · *vas* · *va* · *vamos* · *van* (from *vādere* — the *-oy* of *voy*, like *soy*, *estoy*, *doy*).
- **The near future:** *ir* + *a* + infinitive — *voy a hablar*, *vas a comer*, *va a estudiar* (“I’m / you’re / she’s going to ...”).

- **Possessives:** *mi · tu · su*, and their plurals *mis · tus · sus* — agreeing in number, not gender.

— ¿Qué vas a hacer hoy?
 — Voy a estudiar en mi casa, y luego voy a trabajar. ¿Y tú?
 — Voy a comer con mis amigos. Vamos a un café.

Three threads run through those four lines: *voy a estudiar* and *voy a comer* are the near future (*ir* + *a* + infinitive); *mi casa* and *mis amigos* are the possessives, one singular and one plural; *vamos a un café* is plain *ir a* + a place.

What you built: *ir*, “to go,” the most suppletive verb in Spanish (infinitive ← *īre*; present *voy/vas/va/vamos/van* ← *vādere* → invade, evade), the same *go/went* trick English plays · the near future, *ir a* + infinitive (*voy a hablar* = “I’m going to speak”), Spanish making tomorrow out of the verb “to go” exactly as English and French do · *mí / tu / su* (← *meus / tuus / suus* → my / thy), possessives that agree in number (*mis / tus / sus*) and not gender, plus *tu* (“your”) against *tú* (“you”), the accent doing its quiet work again. Next chapter takes these rules further — from here on the course runs on grammar, not phrases.

Chapter 11

Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers

Two power-verbs — *querer* (“to want”) and *poder* (“can”) — crack their own vowels when you conjugate them. This chapter shows why: one ancient sound-law, two vowels, and a boot-shaped pattern you can predict. It closes with *nuestro*, “our,” which carries the very same crack. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C11-*.md.*

11.1 *querer* — “to want,” and the *e*→*ie* crack

Sounds you’ll need

diphthong-ie — under stress the stem breaks open into *-ie-*: *quiero* is said *KYE-ro*, one gliding syllable, not *kee-EH-ro*.

r-tap — the *r* of *querer* is a single flicked tap of the tongue, like the middle of American *butter*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

querer (“to want”; of a person, “to love”) ← Latin *quaerere*, “to seek, to ask, to want.” Seeking and wanting are the same impulse at the root — and that root is a treasure-house of English.

The plain seeking words: **query**, **quest**, **question** — each one a seeking.

With prefixes: **inquire** (*in-*, “into”), **require** (*re-*, “back”), **acquire** (*ad-*, “toward”), **conquer** (*con-*, “thoroughly seek/win”), **exquisite** (“sought out”), **quorum** (“of whom” the seeking needs enough).

So when you say *quiero*, you are using the same “seek” root as **question** and **conquer**.

Grammar Lens

A **stem** is the part of a verb left when you strip the ending: in *querer*, the stem is *quer-* and the ending is *-er*. A **stem-changing verb** is one whose stem vowel changes when the stress lands on it. In *querer* that stressed *e* breaks into *ie*.

Only *queremos* keeps the plain *e*, because there the stress falls on the ending, not on the stem. Shade in the forms that do change — *yo*, *tú*, *él/ella/usted*, *ellos/ustedes* — and they draw a **boot** shape around the *nosotros/vosotros* gap. That boot is the signature of every stem-changer.

Person	Form	Vowel
yo	<i>quiero</i>	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>
tú	<i>quieres</i>	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>
él / ella / usted	<i>quiere</i>	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>
nosotros	<i>queremos</i>	plain <i>e</i> — unstressed
ellos / ustedes	<i>quieren</i>	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>

Say it out loud until the crack is automatic: *quiero · quieres · quiere · queremos · quieren*. Then put it to work: *Quiero un café* (“I want a coffee”), *Quiero café, por favor*.

11.2 *poder* — “to be able,” and the *o*→*ue* crack

Sounds you’ll need

diphthong-ue — under stress the stem breaks to *-ue-*, with a *w*-glide: *puedo* is said *PWE-do*.

r-tap — again one flicked tap for the *r* of *poder*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poder (“to be able / can”) ← Latin *potēre* (from *posse*), “to be able, to have power.” It is literally the verb *power*.

power itself — English took it through Old French *poeir* ← *potēre*.

potent, **potential**, **omnipotent** (“all-powerful”), **possible** (“able to be”),

posse (“[those] able” to be summoned).

So *puedo* and **power** are the same word — one a Spanish verb, the other its English noun.

Grammar Lens

poder is a stem-changer of the *o→ue* kind: the stressed stem *o* breaks to *ue*, in exactly the same **boot** shape — every form but *nosotros/vosotros*. Just as with *querer*, only the *nosotros* form keeps the plain vowel. Other *o→ue* verbs you will meet: *dormir* (“sleep”) → *duermo*, *volver* (“return”) → *vuelvo*.

Person	Form	Vowel
yo	<i>puedo</i>	<i>o</i> → <i>ue</i>
tú	<i>puedes</i>	<i>o</i> → <i>ue</i>
él / ella / usted	<i>puede</i>	<i>o</i> → <i>ue</i>
nosotros	<i>podemos</i>	plain <i>o</i> — unstressed
ellos / ustedes	<i>pueden</i>	<i>o</i> → <i>ue</i>

Grammar Lens

***poder* + infinitive.** An **infinitive** is the naming form of a verb — the one that ends in *-ar*, *-er*, or *-ir* (*hablar*, “to speak”). Point *poder* at an infinitive and you say what you are *able* to do:

Puedo hablar español. — “I can speak Spanish.”

¿Puedes venir? — “Can you come?”

No puedo. — “I can’t.”

11.3 *e→ie* and *o→ue* — one rule, two vowels

You have now seen both cracks: *querer* → *quiero* (*e→ie*) and *poder* → *puedo* (*o→ue*). They are not two random quirks. They are *one sound-law*, and knowing it turns a “memorize each verb” chore into a pattern you can predict.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The law: in the leap from Latin to Spanish, a **short, stressed *e*** broke into ***ie***, and a **short, stressed *o*** broke into ***ue***. It happened in ordinary nouns, not just verbs.

terra → *tierra* (“earth”) — *e* → *ie*

septem → *siete* (“seven”) — *e* → *ie*

porta → *puerta* (“door”) — *o* → *ue*

novem → *nueve* (“nine”) — *o* → *ue*

The numbers *siete* and *nueve* carry that glide for exactly this reason.

Grammar Lens

In verbs, the stem vowel is stressed in the “boot” forms and unstressed in *nosotros/vosotros* — so it breaks inside the boot and stays plain outside it. That single fact explains both patterns at once.

Person	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i> (<i>querer</i>)	<i>o</i> → <i>ue</i> (<i>poder</i>)
yo	<i>quiero</i>	<i>puedo</i>
tú	<i>quieres</i>	<i>puedes</i>
él / ella / usted	<i>quiere</i>	<i>puede</i>
nosotros	<i>queremos</i>	<i>podemos</i>
ellos / ustedes	<i>quieren</i>	<i>pueden</i>

Same shape both times: the four “corner” forms crack, the *nosotros* form stays plain — the boot. The verb *tener* (→ *tienes*), met earlier, was your first taste of it; now you own the whole rule.

11.4 *nuestro* — “our,” the possessive that agrees fully

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nuestro (“our”) ← Latin *noster*, “our.” You have heard it without knowing: the **Paternoster** is the “*Our* Father,” and a **nostrum** is literally “*our* thing” — a quack’s secret remedy.

Its partner **vuestro** (“your,” said to a group) ← Latin *voster/vester*.

The stem-change fossil: *noster* → *nuestro* shows the very *o*→*ue* break

you just learned — short stressed *o* → *ue*. The possessive cracks exactly like *puerta* and *puedo*.

Grammar Lens

A **possessive** marks who owns the thing. The possessives *mi* (“my”), *tu* (“your”), *su* (“his/her/your-formal”) change only for **number**: *mis*, *tus*, *sus*. *nuestro* is different — it agrees in **both gender and number**, like an ordinary *-o/-a* adjective, so it has **four** forms instead of two. It is the fullest-flexing of the possessives, and *vuestro* does the same (*vuestro*, *vuestra*, *vuestros*, *vuestras*).

	singular	plural
masculine	<i>nuestro libro</i>	<i>nuestros libros</i>
feminine	<i>nuestra casa</i>	<i>nuestras casas</i>

So it is *nuestro coche* (“our car,” masculine) but *nuestra casa* (“our house,” feminine) — you match the noun in both gender and number, just as with *bueno/buena/buenos/buenas*. Say the full set aloud: *nuestro* · *nuestra* · *nuestros* · *nuestras*, then attach nouns — *nuestro coche*, *nuestra casa*, *nuestros amigos*.

11.5 Practice — wanting, being able, and the boot

Two power-verbs and a rule: *querer* (want, *e*→*ie*), *poder* (can, *o*→*ue*), and the stem-change boot that shapes them both — plus *nuestro*, the fully-agreeing “our.” Drill the cracks until *quiero* and *puedo* come without thinking.

Conjugate both boots, out loud. *querer* (*e*→*ie*): *quiero* · *quieres* · *quiere* · *queremos* · *quieren* — only *queremos* stays plain. *poder* (*o*→*ue*): *puedo* · *puedes* · *puede* · *podemos* · *pueden* — only *podemos* stays plain.

Chain the verbs (want to / can + infinitive):

Quiero hablar español. — “I want to speak Spanish.”

Puedo hablar un poco. — “I can speak a little.”

¿*Quieres comer?* — “Do you want to eat?”

¿*Puedes venir?* — “Can you come?”

Vamos a poder. — “We’re going to be able to.”

nuestro, agreeing: *nuestra casa* (feminine), *nuestro coche* (masculine), *nuestros amigos* (masculine plural) — match gender *and* number, unlike *mi/tu/su*.

Say something real:

- *¿Qué quieres hacer?*
- *Quiero ir a un café con nuestros amigos. ¿Puedes venir?*
- *Sí, puedo. Podemos ir ahora.*

Every tool of the chapter is in there: *quiero* (want, $e \rightarrow ie$), *puedes/puedo/podemos* (can, $o \rightarrow ue$), *nuestros* (our, agreeing), and the near future *ir a*.

Why it's said this way

querer does double duty: aimed at a thing it means “to want,” but aimed at a person it means “to love.” *Te quiero* is one of the warmest things one Spanish speaker can say to another — the same verb that orders a coffee. The seeking root never left: to want someone and to seek someone are one word.

What you have built this chapter: *querer* (want, $\leftarrow quaerere$ “seek” $\rightarrow$ **query** / **quest** / **conquer**), the $e \rightarrow ie$ stem-changer; *poder* (can, $\leftarrow potēre \rightarrow$ **power** / **potent** / **possible**), the $o \rightarrow ue$ stem-changer, plus *poder* + infinitive for ability; **the boot** — one sound-law (short stressed $e \rightarrow ie$, $o \rightarrow ue$; *tierra*, *puerta*) cracking all forms but *nosotros/vosotros*; and *nuestro/vuestro* ($\leftarrow noster/voster \rightarrow$ **Paternoster**), the possessive that agrees in gender *and* number, four forms. The next chapter carries the grammar forward — the course now runs on rules.

Chapter 12

Hacer, Decir, and the -go Verb Club

Two workhorse verbs — one for *doing* and *making*, one for *saying* — and the strange little club they belong to, where the “I” form grows a hard *g* out of nowhere. Learn the club once and six of the language’s most-used verbs stop being surprises. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C12-*.md.*

12.1 *hacer* — “to do / to make,” and the *yo*-form that grows a *g*

English splits the work between two verbs: you *do* homework but you *make* coffee. Spanish uses one verb for both — **hacer**. It is one of the language’s workhorses, and it hides two patterns worth naming.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hacer (“to do, to make”) ← Latin *facere* (“to do, to make”). Spanish softened the Latin *f-* into an *h-* that is now completely silent — the same change that turned *fabulārī* into *hablar* (“to speak”) and *filium* into *hijo* (“son”).

The English family from *facere* is enormous: **fact** (“a thing done”), **factory** (“a place of making”), **manufacture** (“made by hand”), **feat**, **feature**.

With prefixes: **affect** and **effect** (*ad-* and *ex-* + *fac-*), **perfect** (“thoroughly done”), **satisfy** (“make enough”), **difficult** (“not easy to do”), **benefit** (“do well”).

So *hacer* and **factory** are the same “make” root — one worn down inside Spanish, one kept crisp on its way into English through Latin.

Sounds you'll need

The *h* in *hacer* is **silent**. Say it *a-THER* (Spain) or *a-SER* (Latin America) — never with an English *h* sound. That silent *h* is the ghost of the Latin *f*: the letter stayed on the page long after the sound left the mouth.

Grammar Lens

hacer behaves normally through most of the present tense — but the *yo* (“I”) form is irregular: it grows a **g**, giving **hago**. This is not a one-off. It is the same move you saw in *tener* → *tengo*: a small, very high-frequency club of “-go” verbs.

Person	Form	Note
yo (I)	hago	irregular — grows a <i>g</i>
tú (you, informal)	haces	regular
él / ella / usted (he, she, you-formal)	hace	regular
nosotros (we)	hacemos	regular
ellos / ustedes (they, you-plural)	hacen	regular

The *g* appears in *hago* and nowhere else.

Why it's said this way

The weather is something Spanish *makes*. Where English says “it is hot,” Spanish says *hace calor* — literally “it makes heat.” So too *hace frío* (“it’s cold,” “it makes cold”) and *hace sol* (“it’s sunny,” “it makes sun”). And the all-purpose everyday question: *¿Qué haces?* — “What are you doing?”

12.2 *decir* — “to say,” the verb with two irregularities at once

decir (“to say / to tell”) is the trickiest verb so far — and the most instructive, because it stacks *two* separate patterns onto one word: the *-go* ending you just met in *hago*, and a change inside the stem (the part of the verb before the ending). Learn *decir* and the whole system clicks together.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

decir (“to say, to tell”) ← Latin *dīcere* (“to say, to tell, to point out”). Its root *dic-* / *dict-* (“say”) runs straight through English.

Plain: **dictate**, **diction**, **dictionary**, **dictaphone** — every one of them about *saying*.

With prefixes: **predict** (“say beforehand”), **contradict** (“say against”), **verdict** (“a true saying”), **indicate** (“point out”), **dedicate**, **edict**, **index**.

So *decir* is the “say” root sitting inside **dictionary** itself — the book of what words *say*.

Sounds you’ll need

In *decir* the stressed stem vowel *e* does *not* break into two vowels. Instead it **closes to *i***: *digo*, *dices*, *dice*. Keep it a single tight *ee* sound — no glide, no second vowel.

Grammar Lens

Irregularity one: the -go yo-form. Exactly like *hago* and *tengo*, the “I” form grows a *g*: **digo**.

Irregularity two: the stem change $e \rightarrow i$. In the forms where the stress lands on the stem, that *e* closes to *i* — a tighter shift than the $e \rightarrow ie$ of *querer*.

Person	Form	Note
yo (I)	 digo	-go form; stem also $\rightarrow i$
tú (you, informal)	 dices	$e \rightarrow i$
él / ella / usted (he, she, you-formal)	 dice	$e \rightarrow i$
nosotros (we)	decimos	plain <i>e</i> — unstressed
ellos / ustedes (they, you-plural)	 dicen	$e \rightarrow i$

The **boot** shape returns: draw a line around the changed forms on the table and they make a boot, with *decimos* standing outside it. Only *decimos* keeps the plain *e*, because there the stress falls on the ending rather than the stem. Everything inside the boot shifts to *i* — and the *yo* corner carries the -go on top of that.

Why it's said this way

The single most useful question a learner owns: *¿Cómo se dice ...?* — “How do you say ...?” It lets you build your own vocabulary out loud, from anyone, forever. Its close companion is *dime* — “tell me.”

12.3 The -go club — one irregular corner, many verbs

You have now met three verbs whose *yo*-form ends in a surprising -go: *tener* → **tengo**, *hacer* → **hago**, *decir* → **digo**. That is not three coincidences — it is a **club**. Learn the membership once and you never have to re-learn the shape.

Grammar Lens

Most Spanish verbs build a tidy *yo*-form: *hablo* (“I speak”), *como* (“I eat”), *vivo* (“I live”). But a small set of very common verbs **grow a hard g** in the *yo*-form only. The rest of the present tense behaves normally.

Verb	Meaning	<i>yo</i> -form	Met it?
tener	to have	tengo	yes — Chapter 8
hacer	to do / to make	hago	yes — this chapter
decir	to say	digo	yes — this chapter
poner	to put	pongo	coming
salir	to leave / go out	salgo	coming
venir	to come	vengo	coming

Three you know, three still to come — and every one follows the same rule: **-go in the *yo*-form, regular elsewhere**, with any stem-change stacked on top, as in *digo*.

Why it's said this way

Why the *g*? A Latin fossil. The *g* is an inheritance. Latin's first-person forms and old sound-laws left a **velar** sound — a *g* or *k* made at the back of the mouth — clinging to these particular verbs, and Spanish tidied it into a clean -go. You do not need the history to use them, but it explains why the club is old and closed: these are among the *most-used*

verbs in the language, and the oldest, most-used words are exactly the ones that keep their irregularities. English does the same thing — **am** / **was**, **go** / **went**.

12.4 Practice — doing, making, saying

This chapter added two workhorse verbs — *hacer* (“do / make”) and *decir* (“say”) — and the *-go* club that unites their *yo*-forms with *tengo*. Time to make them automatic.

Drill 1 — the *-go* *yo*-forms. Say the *yo*-form for each, then the *tú*-form, which drops the *g*:

Verb	<i>yo</i>	<i>tú</i>
<i>hacer</i>	hago	haces
<i>decir</i>	digo	dices (mind the $e \rightarrow i$)
<i>tener</i>	tengo	tienes (mind the $e \rightarrow ie$)

What do all three *yo*-forms share? The *-go*. And what happens to it in the *tú*-form? It *drops* — the *-go* is *yo*-only.

Drill 2 — say the full present. Run each verb top to bottom: *hacer*: *hago* · *haces* · *hace* · *hacemos* · *hacen*. *decir*: *digo* · *dices* · *dice* · *decimos* · *dicen* — the boot again, with only *decimos* keeping the plain *e*.

Drill 3 — put it to use. Say each one out loud:

¿Qué haces? — “What are you doing?”

Hago la tarea. — “I’m doing the homework.”

¿Cómo se dice “window”? — “How do you say ‘window’?”

Hace frío hoy. — “It’s cold today” (weather with *hacer* — “it makes cold”).

Drill 4 — the root families. Name an English cousin from the same Latin root: *hacer* ← *facere* → **fact**, **factory**, **perfect**, **manufacture** — any of them. *decir* ← *dicere* → **dictate**, **diction**, **predict**, **verdict** — any of them.

Recall. Give the *yo*-forms of *hacer*, *decir*, and *tener* (*hago*, *digo*, *tengo* — the *-go* club). In *decir*, which form escapes the $e \rightarrow i$ boot, and why? (*decimos* — the stress falls on the ending.) How does Spanish say “it’s hot”? (*Hace calor*.) You can now *do*, *make*, and *say* in Spanish — and you have seen that the language’s most irregular verbs are its most-used, oldest words.

Chapter 13

Poner, Salir, Venir — Completing the -go Club

Three verbs remain in the small club of Spanish verbs whose *I* form grows an extra **g**: *pongo, salgo, vengo*. They hide a Latin “place” root, a Latin “leap” root, and a Latin “come” root — and the last of them stacks *two* irregularities at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C13-*.md.*

13.1 *poner* — “to put,” and the club gains a member

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poner (“to put / to place”) ← Latin *pōnere*, “to put, to place, to set down.” Its stem *pon-/pos-* (“place”) is one of the busiest roots in English.

Bare: **position**, **pose**, **posit** — each one a *placing*.

With prefixes: **compose** (“place together”), **deposit** (“place down”), **expose** (“place out”), **oppose** / **opponent** (“place against”), **propose** (“place forward”), **postpone** (“place after”), **component**.

So *poner* and **position** share the same “place” root — when you *poner* something, you are putting it in its *pōnere*.

Grammar Lens

A verb’s **infinitive** is its plain naming form (“to put”), and Spanish infinitives end in *-ar*, *-er*, or *-ir*. *poner* is an *-er* verb, and it behaves like a perfectly regular one *everywhere except* the *yo* (“I”) form, which grows a **g**: **pongo**. That single odd corner is what marks a verb as a

member of the -go club, alongside *tengo* (“I have”), *hago* (“I do/make”), and *digo* (“I say”).

Person	Form	Note
yo (I)	pongo	-go, like <i>tengo</i>
tú (you, informal)	pones	regular
él / ella / usted	pone	regular
nosotros (we)	ponemos	regular
ellos / ustedes	ponen	regular

Sounds you’ll need

The *g* in **pongo** is a *hard g*, as in English *go* — never the soft *g* of English *gem*. The same hard -go you hear in *tengo*.

Why it’s said this way

The everyday payoff: *poner la mesa* (“to set the table”), *poner música* (“to put on music”), and the reflexive *ponerse* — “to put on (clothes)” or “to become”: *me pongo nervioso*, “I get nervous.” One verb covers setting, playing, dressing, and becoming.

13.2 *salir* — “to go out,” from a verb that meant “to leap”

13.2. SALIR — “TO GO OUT,” FROM A VERB THAT MEANT “TO LEAP”⁹⁷

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

salir (“to leave, to go out”) ← Latin *salīre*, “to leap, to jump, to spring.” Over time “leaping out” softened into simply “going out” — but the leap survives all across English.

Bare: **salient** (“leaping out,” so: prominent, sticking out), **sally** (“a sudden rush out”), **somersault** (*sopra* + *saltus*, “a leap over”).

With prefixes: **assail** / **assault** (“leap at”), **resilient** (“leap back”), **result** (“leap back out”), **insult** (“leap upon”).

And a fish: *salīre* gave Latin *salmō*, “the leaper,” for the **salmon** that leaps upstream.

So every time you say *salgo* (“I go out”), you are using the old *leap* verb behind **salient** and **salmon**.

Grammar Lens

salir is an *-ir* verb, and the story is exactly *poner*’s: regular everywhere but the *yo* form, which grows the **g** — **salgo**.

Person	Form	Note
yo (I)	salgo	<i>-go</i> , like <i>pongo</i> / <i>tengo</i>
tú (you, informal)	sales	regular
él / ella / usted	sale	regular
nosotros (we)	salimos	regular
ellos / ustedes	salen	regular

Why it’s said this way

salir de casa is “to leave the house”; *salir con alguien* is “to go out with someone” — that is, to date. And *la salida* is “the **exit**” — the sign you will read at every station. Note that English *exit* comes from a *different* Latin verb, *exīre* (“go out”); Spanish chose the *leaping* one instead.

13.3 *venir* — “to come,” cracked *and* g-grown

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

venir (“to come”) ← Latin *venīre*, “to come.” Its root *ven-/vent-* comes toward English from every direction:

adventure (*ad-venīre*, “what comes to you”), **event** (“what comes out”), **convene** / **convention** (“come together”), **invent** (“come upon”), **prevent** (“come before”), **intervene**, **revenue** (“what comes back”), **avenue** (“a coming-toward”), and **souvenir** (from French, “a thing that comes to mind”).

Grammar Lens

venir is **doubly irregular** — it stacks two changes at once.

(1) The **-go yo form**, like *pongo* / *salgo* / *tengo*: **vengo**.

(2) The ***e* → *ie* stem-change**. The **stem** is the part of the verb before the ending — here *ven-*. When the stress of the word falls on that stem, its *e* breaks apart into *ie*: *vienes*, *viene*, *vienen*. When the stress falls on the ending instead, the *e* stays plain: *venimos*.

Write the five forms in a column and the changed ones outline the shape of a **boot**: everything cracks to *ie* except *venimos*, which sits outside it, and the *yo* corner carries the *-go*.

Person	Form	Note
yo (I)	vengo	the <i>-go</i> form
tú (you, informal)	vienes	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>
él / ella / usted	viene	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>
nosotros (we)	venimos	plain <i>e</i> — unstressed
ellos / ustedes	vienen	<i>e</i> → <i>ie</i>

Sounds you’ll need

Two things to hear. The *g* of **vengo** is the hard *-go* again. And *ie* is a **diphthong** — two vowel sounds glided together in one syllable: *vienes* is *vee-EH-nes*.

This is the exact shape of *tener* (*tengo* / *tienes*) — *venir* is its mirror twin: *Vengo de España* (“I come from Spain”), ¿*Vienes?* (“Are you coming?”).

13.4 The club is complete

All six members, in one place: *tengo · hago · digo · pongo · salgo · vengo*. Every one of them is irregular in the *yo* form only — the rest of each verb is regular, plus whatever stem-change it carries.

Infinitive	<i>yo</i> form	Kind
hacer (to do/make)	hago	plain -go
poner (to put)	pongo	plain -go
salir (to go out)	salgo	plain -go
decir (to say)	digo	-go + <i>e</i> → <i>i</i> (dices/dice)
tener (to have)	tengo	-go + <i>e</i> → <i>ie</i> (tienes)
venir (to come)	vengo	-go + <i>e</i> → <i>ie</i> (vienes)

The two *e* → *ie* twins run side by side, and only the *we* forms keep the plain *e* — the boot again:

<i>tener</i>	<i>venir</i>
tengo	vengo
tienes	vienes
tiene	viene
tenemos	venimos
tienen	vienen

Now put them to work. Say each aloud:

Vengo de casa y pongo la mesa. — “I come from home and set the table.”

Salgo a las ocho. — “I leave at eight.”

¿Qué haces? — *Hago la cena.* — “What are you doing? — I’m making dinner.”

Digo que sí. — “I say yes.”

And one English cousin for each new root: *poner* ← *pōnere* → **position** / **compose** / **deposit**; *salir* ← *salīre* → **salient** / **salmon** / **somersault**; *venir* ← *venīre* → **adventure** / **event** / **convene**. You now hold the whole irregular -go corner of Spanish — its oldest, most-used verbs, mastered as one pattern.

Chapter 14

The Preterite — Your First Past Tense

Until now everything you have said lived in the present. This chapter crosses into “what happened”: the **preterite**, Spanish’s everyday past. It opens with the strangest fact in the language — “I was” and “I went” are the same word — and closes with a pattern that covers thousands of verbs and hangs on a single accent mark. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C14-*.md.*

14.1 *fui* — the past arrives, and two verbs become one

Spanish’s everyday past tense is called the **preterite**: “I spoke, I went, I was” — an action finished, sealed off, done. And it opens with the most memorable oddity in the whole language: the verbs *ser* (“to be”) and *ir* (“to go”) have the *exact same* preterite. *Fui* means both “**I was**” and “**I went**.”

<i>ser</i> / <i>ir</i> (the same!)	
yo	fui
tú	fuiste
él / ella / usted	fue
nosotros	fuimos
ellos / ustedes	fueron

One set of forms, *two* verbs. There is no separate past for “to go” — Spanish simply reuses “to be.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

fui ← Latin *fuī*, “I have been.” Here is the twist: Latin had *two* different roots for “to be.” The present *sum* / *es* / *est* (which became *soy* / *eres* / *es*) came from the ancient root PIE **es-*. The perfect *fuī* came from a *different* root, PIE **b^huH-*, “to grow, to become” — and that is the very root of English **be** and **been**, and (by way of Greek and Latin) **future** and **physics**.

Spanish stitched the two roots into a single verb. That patchwork is called **suppletion** — the same thing English does with *go* / *went*, two unrelated words serving one verb.

Grammar Lens

Then *ir* (“to go”) borrowed *fuī* as well, because Latin’s own past of *īre* (“to go”) had worn away to almost nothing. So “to be” and “to go” *merged* in the past tense, and only **context** tells them apart:

Fui *a Madrid*. — “I **went** to Madrid.” (movement → *ir*)

Fui *profesor*. — “I **was** a teacher.” (a state → *ser*)

The giveaway is usually what follows: *a* + a place means going; a description or a role means being.

Sounds you’ll need

stress-final — the preterite loves the *final* syllable. *fui* and *fue* are single syllables; then *fuiste*, *fuimos*, *fueron*. Say the set aloud pushing the weight to the end: *fui* · *fuiste* · *fue* · *fuimos* · *fueron*.

diphthong -ui- — *ui* is one glide, not two beats: “fwee,” not “foo-ee.”

14.2 *hablé* — the regular past, built on an accent

Fui was irregular — a one-off you memorize. Now the **pattern** that covers thousands of verbs. Take any regular *-ar* verb, drop the *-ar*, and add the preterite endings. The whole tense hangs on one small mark: the **accent**.

Drop *-ar* from **hablar** (“to speak”) and add:

preterite		
yo	hablé	(accent on é)
tú	hablaste	
él / ella / usted	habló	(accent on ó)
nosotros	hablamos	(no accent)
ellos / ustedes	hablaron	

Grammar Lens

Set this beside the **present** tense of the same verb — *hablo, hablas, habla* — and the difference is almost entirely *where the stress lands*: *HA-blo* (“I speak,” now) versus *ha-BLÉ* (“I spoke,” done). The written accent is not decoration; it **carries the tense**. Move the stress to the end and the past tense announces itself.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

These endings are worn-down Latin **perfect** forms. Latin *amāvī* (“I loved”) → *amé*; *amāvistī* → *amaste*; *amāvit* → *amó*. The *-āv-* in the middle dissolved away and left behind the *stressed final vowel* that Spanish now crowns with an accent.

So *hablé* is Latin (*fabulāvī*) with the middle chewed away — the same erosion you have watched all along, this time applied to an entire tense.

Why it’s said this way

One trap — *hablamos*. The *nosotros* form is *identical* in present and preterite: *hablamos* is both “we speak” and “we spoke.” Nothing in the word itself decides. Only **context** — or a time-word such as *ayer* (“yesterday”) — tells them apart: *hablamos ayer* = “we spoke yesterday.” Spanish speakers lean on *ayer, anoche, el año pasado* to do the work the verb ending leaves undone.

Sounds you’ll need

accent-acute — the written ´ marks the *stressed* vowel: *habl-É, habl-Ó*. Practise the flip: *hablo* → *hablé*, *habla* → *habló*. Then a full sentence: *Ayer hablé con María* (“Yesterday I spoke with María”).

14.3 Practice — past against present

This chapter gave you the past: the shared *ser/ir* preterite (*fui*) and the regular *-ar* pattern (*hablé*). The skill now is switching between *now* and *then* without stumbling.

Drill 1 — say the two paradigms. *fui · fuiste · fue · fuimos · fueron*. Then: *hablé · hablaste · habló · hablamos · hablaron*.

Drill 2 — the accent flips the tense. Say each present form, then its preterite twin; the stress jumps to the end.

present		preterite
<i>hablo</i> (I speak)	→	<i>hablé</i> (I spoke)
<i>habla</i> (s/he speaks)	→	<i>habló</i> (s/he spoke)
<i>trabajo</i> (I work)	→	<i>trabajé</i> (I worked)

What one thing changed? The **accent** — the stressed syllable moved to the end.

Drill 3 — *ser* or *ir*? Context decides.

Fui a la escuela. → *ir* — “I went.”

Fui estudiante. → *ser* — “I was a student.”

Ella fue muy amable. → *ser* — “She was very kind.”

Ellos fueron a España. → *ir* — “They went.”

Drill 4 — put it to use. Say each aloud:

Ayer hablé con mi madre. — “Yesterday I spoke with my mother.”

Fui al mercado y compré pan. — “I went to the market and bought bread.”

Fuimos amigos. — “We were friends.”

Which two verbs share *fui* / *fue*? *Ser* and *ir*. How does the accent turn *hablo* into *habló*? It moves the stress to the end — present becomes preterite. And in *Fui a casa*, be or go? Go — *ir*. You can now speak in the past: the course has crossed from “what is” to “what happened.”

Chapter 15

Completing the Preterite — Three Families, One Question

The past tense finishes here. The *-er* and *-ir* verbs hand you a gift — one set of endings for two conjugations — and then a handful of very old verbs pull the stress backwards and drop their accents entirely. One question sorts all of them: where does the stress land? *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C15-*.md.*

15.1 *comí, viví* — two conjugations become one

You have the *-ar* past (*hablé*, “I spoke”). Now the other two families. Here Spanish does you a favour it never does in the present tense: *-er* and *-ir* verbs take the *exact same* preterite endings. Learn one set, get both.

Drop the *-er* or *-ir* from the infinitive, and add *-í, -iste, -ió, -imos, -ieron*.

person	<i>comer</i> (“to eat”)	<i>vivir</i> (“to live”)
<i>yo</i> (I)	comí	viví
<i>tú</i> (you, informal)	comiste	viviste
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	comió	vivió
<i>nosotros</i> (we)	comimos	vivimos
<i>ellos / ustedes</i> (they / you all)	comieron	vivieron

Look down the two columns: the endings are *identical*. That is not true in the present, where *-er* and *-ir* pull apart (*comemos* versus *vivimos*). In the past, the two conjugations **merge**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

These endings are worn-down Latin **perfect** forms — *-ī*, *-istī*, *-it*. The middle one barely changed at all: Latin *-istī* → Spanish *-iste* (*comiste*, *viviste*). Two thousand years, one dropped vowel.

Sounds you'll need

The written accent marks the **stressed final vowel**: *comí*, *comió*. Say them with the loudness at the very end of the word. Stress at the end = the past.

Grammar Lens

One trap. For *-ir* verbs, the *nosotros* form is the *same* in present and preterite: *vivimos* means both “we live” and “we lived” (just like *hablamos* in the previous chapter). But for *-er* verbs it differs: *comemos* (“we eat”) versus *comimos* (“we ate”). One vowel does the whole job.

Try it aloud: *comí*, *comiste*, *comió*, *comimos*, *comieron*; then *viví*, *viviste*, *vivió*, *vivimos*, *vivieron* — hear the same endings. Then a whole sentence: *Ayer comí paella* (“Yesterday I ate paella”).

15.2 *tuve, hice, estuve* — the strong preterites

Everything so far pushed the stress *to the end*: *hablé*, *comí*, *comió*. Now meet the verbs that do the opposite. They pull the stress *back into the stem* — and so they lose their accent marks entirely. Spanish calls them *pretéritos fuertes*, “**strong**” preterites: strong because the *stem* carries the weight.

The stem changes, and then one shared set of endings follows: *-e*, *-iste*, *-o*, *-imos*, *-ieron*.

person	<i>tener</i> → <i>tuv-</i>	<i>hacer</i> → <i>hic-</i>	<i>estar</i> → <i>estuv-</i>
<i>yo</i>	tuve	hice	estuve
<i>tú</i>	tuviste	hiciste	estuviste
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	tuvo	hizo	estuvo
<i>nosotros</i>	tuvimos	hicimos	estuvimos
<i>ellos / ustedes</i>	tuvieron	hicieron	estuvieron

Grammar Lens

The accent rule, inverted. Compare the *yo* and *él* forms across the three families.

family	<i>yo</i>	<i>él / ella</i>	stressed syllable	accent?
-ar (<i>hablar</i>)	hablé	habló	the ending	yes
-er / -ir (<i>comer</i>)	comí	comió	the ending	yes
strong (<i>tener</i>)	TU ve	TU vo	the stem	no

Sounds you'll need

Say them out loud back to back: *habló ... TUvo*. The written accent isn't decoration — it is telling you *where the stress went*. There is no accent on a strong preterite because the stress never left the stem.

Note the *yo* ending too: -e, not -é — *tuve*, not *tuvé*.

Grammar Lens

One spelling swerve. *Hacer* gives **hizo**, not *hico* — Spanish swaps *c* → *z* before *o* to keep the sound the same. The letter changes so the pronunciation won't.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Why are these irregular? Because they are **old**. Latin had two ways to build a perfect, and these verbs kept the “strong” one, inherited whole rather than rebuilt: *tenuī* → **tuve**, *fēcī* → **hice**, *stetī / stāre* → **estuve**.

The regular -ar / -er / -ir patterns are the tidy replacements that spread later; the strong verbs are the most-used ones, worn smooth by frequency and never re-made. Notice that *tuv-* and *estuv-* even share the same -uv- shape.

Say them aloud: *tuve, tuviste, tuvo, tuvimos, tuvieron*; then *hice, hiciste, hizo* — hear the *z*. Then the contrast pair, *habló ... TUvo*. And a sentence: *Ayer estuve en casa* (“Yesterday I was at home”).

15.3 Practice — three families, one question

You now have the *entire* everyday past tense. Three families — and one question sorts them: **where does the stress land?**

	<i>yo</i>	<i>tú</i>	<i>él / ella</i>	<i>nosotros</i>	<i>ellos</i>
-ar (<i>hablar</i>)	hablé	hablaste	habló	hablamos	hablaron
-er (<i>comer</i>)	comí	comiste	comió	comimos	comieron
-ir (<i>vivir</i>)	viví	viviste	vivió	vivimos	vivieron
strong (<i>tener</i>)	tuve	tuviste	tuvo	tuvimos	tuvieron
<i>ser / ir</i>	fui	fuiste	fue	fuimos	fueron

Two things to notice. First, rows two and three are the *same* — *-er* and *-ir* merged. Second, only the first three rows carry accents, and only on *yo* and *él*. Those are exactly the forms where the stress is on the ending.

Grammar Lens

The stress test. Read any preterite and ask: is the loud syllable the *last* one?

Yes → regular. Accent on *yo* and *él / ella* (*hablé, habló, comí, comió*).

No, it's the stem → **strong**. No accent (*TUve, HIce, ESTUvo*).

Some forms live in both tenses, and only context decides.

form	could be	which?
<i>hablamos</i>	we speak / we spoke	either — context decides
<i>vivimos</i>	we live / we lived	either — context decides
<i>comemos / comimos</i>	we eat / we ate	distinct — the vowel tells you
<i>fui</i>	I was / I went	either — <i>ser</i> and <i>ir</i> share it

Practise aloud: the *yo* forms straight down all five rows — *hablé, comí, viví, tuve, fui*. Then whole sentences: *Ayer hablé con mi madre y comí en casa* (“Yesterday I spoke with my mother and ate at home”); *Hice la comida* (“I made the food”) — stem stress, no accent; *Fui al mercado* (“I went to the market”). Finally say the diagnostic itself: last syllable loud → accent; stem loud → none.

Next chapter: talking about the past that *kept going* — the imperfect.

Chapter 16

The Imperfect — the Past That Kept Going

One past tense says a thing finished; this one says a thing was *going on*. It is also the most regular tense in the language, with exactly three irregular verbs in the whole of Spanish — and then one genuinely new distinction to learn to think in. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C16-*.md.*

16.1 *hablaba, comía* — the past that kept going

A **tense** is the shape a verb takes to place an action in time. Spanish has two ordinary past tenses. The **preterite** reports that a past thing **finished**: *hablé*, “I spoke.” The **imperfect** reports that a past thing was **going on**, or happened over and over: “I **was speaking**,” “I **used to speak**.” That is what this whole chapter is about.

And here is the good news: the imperfect is the **most regular tense in the language**. Drop the infinitive ending (*-ar, -er, -ir*) and add one of two sets of endings.

Person	<i>-ar</i> (<i>hablar</i>)	<i>-er</i> / <i>-ir</i> (<i>comer, vivir</i>)
yo	habl aba	com ía / viv ía
tú	hablab as	com ías
él / ella / usted	hablab a	com ía
nosotros	habláb amos	com íamos
ellos / ustedes	hablab an	com ían

The ***-er*** and ***-ir*** verbs share one set again — the third time now (they also shared in the preterite). Two conjugations, one pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

-aba ← Latin *-ābam* · **-ía** ← Latin *-ēbam*.

Same Latin ending, two fates. The *b* survived whole in *-aba* (*-ābam* → *-aba*), but wore away in the other set (*-ēbam* → *-ea* → *-ía*). One sound, two outcomes, inside the same language.

Sounds you'll need

accent-acute — *hablábamos*: the stress falls **three syllables back** (*ha-BLÁ-ba-mos*), and Spanish writes an accent whenever it does. This is the *only* form in the *-ar* set that takes one.

hiatus-ia — *comía*: here the accent **splits the vowels**. Without it, *ia* would be a single syllable (as in *piano*); with it, *co-mí-a* is three. **Every** form in the *-er/-ir* set needs it.

Grammar Lens

One trap, and a broken rule. *Yo hablaba* and *él hablaba* are **identical** — the ending no longer tells you who is speaking. Spanish normally *drops* its subject pronouns, because the ending carries the person; in the imperfect the ending stopped doing that job, so the pronoun steps back in. You will hear *yo* said out loud here far more often than in the present tense.

Say them straight through: *hablaba, hablabas, hablaba, hablábamos, hablaban · comía, comías, comía, comíamos, comían*. And in a sentence: *Cuando era niño, hablaba español en casa* (“When I was a child, I used to speak Spanish at home”).

16.2 *era, iba, veía* — all three of them

The preterite hands you a pile of strong, irregular forms to memorise. Here is the compensation: the imperfect has **three** irregular verbs. Not three families — **three verbs**, in the entire language.

Person	<i>ser</i> → era	<i>ir</i> → iba	<i>ver</i> → veía
yo	era	iba	veía
tú	eras	ibas	veías
él / ella / usted	era	iba	veía
nosotros	éramos	íbamos	veíamos
ellos / ustedes	eran	iban	veían

That is the entire irregular inventory. Every other verb in Spanish — thousands of them — takes the regular endings from the last section.

And *ver* barely counts: it simply keeps an extra *-e-* from its older form *veer*, then conjugates normally (*ve-* + *-ía*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

era ← Latin *eram*, from the same *es-* root that gives *ser*, *soy*, *es* — and English **is** and **are**. So *ser* uses that ancient root in the present *and* the imperfect, but jumps to a different verb entirely, Latin *fuī*, in the preterite: *era* versus *fue*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

***ir*'s third Latin verb.** Spanish *ir* (“to go”) is stitched together out of **three different Latin verbs**, one per tense:

present *voy*, *vas*, *va* ← Latin *vādere*, “to advance”

preterite *fui*, *fuiste*, *fue* ← Latin *fuī*, from *esse*

imperfect ***iba*, *ibas*, *iba*** ← Latin *īre* — *ir*'s **own infinitive**

The imperfect is the **one place** the original *īre* survives conjugated. The infinitive *ir* and the imperfect *iba* are the last two pieces of the real verb; everything else was borrowed from elsewhere.

Sounds you'll need

stress-antepenultimate — **éramos** and **íbamos** take a written accent for exactly the reason *hablábamos* does: the stress lands three syllables back (*É-ra-mos*, *Í-ba-mos*). Those two are the only accented forms in the irregular set apart from *ver*, whose accent is the vowel-splitting kind (*ve-í-a*).

Say them: *era*, *eras*, *era*, *éramos*, *eran* · *iba*, *ibas*, *iba*, *íbamos*, *iban*. In a sentence: *Cuando era niño, iba a la escuela* (“When I was a child, I used

to go to school”). And say the three sources out loud: *voy* ← *vādere* · *fui* ← *fuī* · *iba* ← *īre*.

16.3 Practice — two pasts, one choice

You now have **both** past tenses. English marks this difference only sometimes, and never with an ending — so this is a genuinely **new distinction** to think in, not merely new forms to learn.

	preterite	imperfect
what it does	a completed event	an ongoing or habitual state
shape of time	a point	a line
English	“I ate”	“I was eating” / “I used to eat”
typical clues	<i>ayer, una vez, de repente</i>	<i>siempre, todos los días, mientras</i>

Comí = the meal happened and ended. **Comía** = I was in the middle of it, or I did it regularly.

Grammar Lens

Background and interruption. The classic pairing: the imperfect sets the scene, the preterite breaks it.

Hablaba con María cuando llegó Juan. (“I was talking to María when Juan arrived.”)

The talking is the **line**; the arriving is the **point** that lands on it. Swap the two tenses and the sentence stops making sense.

Why it’s said this way

Verbs that change meaning. With a few verbs the choice does not just shift the shape of time — it changes **what the word means**. The logic is consistent: the imperfect gives you the *state*, the preterite gives you the *instant the state began*. Knowing → the moment of finding out.

verb	imperfect (state)	preterite (the moment it started)
<i>saber</i>	<i>sabía</i> — I knew	<i>supe</i> — I found out
<i>conocer</i>	<i>conocía</i> — I knew (a person)	<i>conocí</i> — I met
<i>tener</i>	<i>tenía</i> — I had	<i>tuve</i> — I got, received
<i>querer</i>	<i>quería</i> — I wanted	<i>quise</i> — I tried

(And the negative sharpens it further: *no quise* = “I **refused**.”)

Drill — **which tense?** Decide before you read the answer.

sentence	tense
“Every summer we went to Spain.”	imperfect (<i>íbamos</i>) — habitual
“Yesterday we went to Spain.”	preterite (<i>fuimos</i>) — one event
“She was tall.”	imperfect (<i>era</i>) — a lasting state
“The concert was yesterday.”	preterite (<i>fue</i>) — a bounded event

Say these aloud: *Comía cuando llamaste* (“I was eating when you called”) · the pair *sabía* “I knew” ... *supe* “I found out” · *Cuando era niño, iba a la playa todos los veranos*.

Recall it all: preterite or imperfect for a **habit**? (**Imperfect**.) Which tense sets the background, and which interrupts it? (Imperfect **sets**, preterite **interrupts**.) What is the difference between *conocía* and *conocí*? (“I **knew** someone” versus “I **met** them.”) How many irregular imperfects are there? (**Three**.) And the one-word test, the thing to keep: **line** → imperfect; **point** → preterite. Next chapter: talking about what **will** happen.

Chapter 17

The Future and the Conditional — One Weld, Twice

Two whole tenses built from a single trick: glue an infinitive to the verb “to have.” Use the present of “have” and you get the future; use its past and you get “would.” One machine, one part swapped, and a seam you can still see. *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C17-*.md.*

17.1 *hablaré* — the future, welded shut

A **tense** is the shape a verb takes to say *when* something happens. Spanish has two ways to talk about what is coming. One you can already build out of small parts — *voy a hablar*, “I am going to speak.” The other is a single word, and it has the best origin story of any Spanish tense.

Grammar Lens

The **infinitive** is a verb’s plain dictionary form — *hablar* (“to speak”), *comer* (“to eat”), *vivir* (“to live”). Every other Spanish tense begins by *stripping* that ending off: you cut *-ar* from *hablar* and build on *habl-*.

The future does not. It keeps the infinitive whole and stacks endings on top of it. And because the infinitive stays intact, *one* set of endings serves all three verb families: *hablar* → *hablaré*, *comer* → *comeré*, *vivir* → *viviré*.

Person	Future of <i>hablar</i>
<i>yo</i> (I)	<i>hablaré</i>
<i>tú</i> (you, informal)	<i>hablarás</i>
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	<i>hablará</i>
<i>nosotros</i> (we)	<i>hablaremos</i>
<i>ellos / ustedes</i>	<i>hablarán</i>

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hablaré is not one piece but two, fused: *hablar* + *he*. That *he* is “I have,” the present tense of *haber* (“to have”) ← Latin *habēre* — the root English borrowed in **habit** (“what one has”), **habitat**, **inhabit**, **able** and **ability** (from *habēre*’s compound *habēlis*, “handy to have”), **prohibit**, **exhibit**.

Latin had its own future — *amābō*, “I will love” — and it **died out**. Speakers replaced it with a phrase:

amāre habeo — “*I have to love*” → “*I will love*.”

Infinitive + the verb *habēre*, “to have.” This is exactly the English “**I have to go**,” which also slides from obligation toward the future. Then the Spanish phrase **fused**. Say *hablar he* fast enough, often enough, for enough centuries, and it closes into one word.

Stage	Form
two words	<i>hablar + he</i>
squeezed	<i>hablar-he</i>
welded	<i>hablaré</i>

So the endings are not really endings. They are the present tense of *haber*, worn down to a suffix. Line the two lists up side by side:

<i>haber</i> (present)	Future ending
<i>he</i>	-é
<i>has</i>	-ás
<i>ha</i>	-á
<i>hemos</i>	-emos
<i>han</i>	-án

They are the same list. A **compound** tense — two words — that closed up into a **simple** one, a single word. That is the exact reverse of what French and Italian did with their compound past, which stayed open as two words.

Why it's said this way

The seam Spanish sealed over is still faintly open next door. Portuguese welded its future too (*falarei* is one word), but in **formal European Portuguese** a pronoun can still be lodged *inside* it:

falá-lo-ei — “I will speak it.”

That *-lo-* is sitting in the join, between *falar* and *ei*. It is a leftover, not the normal pattern — Brazilian Portuguese does not do it, and neither does ordinary speech. But it shows you the weld from the outside.

Sounds you'll need

Every future form except *nosotros* carries a written accent, and the accent falls on the very last syllable: *ha-bla-RÉ*, *ha-bla-RÁS*, *ha-bla-RÁN*. That final stress is the ghost of the second word — *he*, *has*, *han* — that used to stand there on its own.

hablaremos needs no accent: its stress already lands where Spanish expects it by default.

17.2 *hablaría* — the same weld, one tense over

Same machine, one part swapped. Whole infinitive again, new endings.

Person	Conditional of <i>hablar</i>
<i>yo</i>	<i>hablaría</i>
<i>tú</i>	<i>hablarías</i>
<i>él / ella / usted</i>	<i>hablaría</i>
<i>nosotros</i>	<i>hablaríamos</i>
<i>ellos / ustedes</i>	<i>hablarían</i>

Look hard at those endings: *-ía*, *-ías*, *-íamos*, *-ían*. They are exactly the *-er/-ir* **imperfect** endings — *comía*, *comías*, *comíamos*, *comían* (“I used to eat,” and so on).

Grammar Lens

They are identical because they *are* the same. The future welds the infinitive to the **present** of *haber*; the conditional welds the same infinitive to the **imperfect** of *haber* — its “used to” past.

Tense	Infinitive +	Result
future	<i>haber</i> present (<i>he, has, ha...</i>)	<i>hablaré</i>
conditional	<i>haber</i> imperfect (<i>había, habías...</i>)	<i>hablaría</i>

Strictly, what fused was the older, shorter form *avía* — which is why you get *hablaría* and not *hablarhabía*. The modern *había* is the same word, un-worn. One trick, two tenses of the same auxiliary: that is the whole chapter.

Sounds you’ll need

The accent on *-ía* does real work. Left alone, *i* and *a* would glide together into one syllable. The accent **breaks** them apart, so *hablaría* is three-and-a-bit syllables — *ha-bla-RÍ-a* — with the stressed *í* standing on its own.

Now, what the conditional is *for*. Three jobs:

Use	Example	English
would — hypothetical	<i>Hablaría con él.</i>	“I would speak with him.”
politeness — softening	<i>¿Podrías ayudarme?</i>	“Could you help me?”
future-in-the-past	<i>Dijo que hablaría.</i>	“He said he would speak.”

Why it’s said this way

That third use is the neat one: measured from a point in the *past*, the conditional *is* the future — which makes sense once you remember that a past tense of *haber* is sitting inside it.

The second use is the one you will reach for daily. *Me gustaría...* (“I would like...”) is about the politest opening in Spanish: the conditional turns a demand into a wish, in every language that has one.

17.3 Practice — ten stems, two tenses

A handful of verbs bend the infinitive before welding it. The good news: **the same bent stem serves both tenses**, so you learn ten shapes once and get twenty conjugations. They fall into three families.

1. Drop the vowel. The infinitive's last vowel simply goes.

Verb	Stem	Future	Conditional
<i>poder</i> (to be able)	<i>podr-</i>	<i>podré</i>	<i>podría</i>
<i>querer</i> (to want)	<i>querr-</i>	<i>querré</i>	<i>querría</i>
<i>saber</i> (to know)	<i>sabr-</i>	<i>sabré</i>	<i>sabría</i>
<i>haber</i> (to have)	<i>habr-</i>	<i>habré</i>	<i>habría</i>

2. Drop the vowel, then wedge in a *d*. Dropping alone would leave *-n'r-* or *-l'r-* jammed together, and Old Spanish refused to leave it that way — so a *d* slid in to prop the cluster apart.

Verb	Would be	Becomes	Future
<i>tener</i> (to have)	<i>ten-r-</i>	<i>tendr-</i>	<i>tendré</i>
<i>poner</i> (to put)	<i>pon-r-</i>	<i>pondr-</i>	<i>pondré</i>
<i>venir</i> (to come)	<i>ven-r-</i>	<i>vendr-</i>	<i>vendré</i>
<i>salir</i> (to leave)	<i>sal-r-</i>	<i>saldr-</i>	<i>saldré</i>

Sounds you'll need

It is not that modern Spanish cannot say those clusters — *honra*, *sonrisa*, *alrededor* are perfectly ordinary. It is that when this particular squeeze happened, the language fixed it.

It even tried a **second** solution first: medieval Spanish also said *terné*, *porné*, *verné*, swapping the two consonants around instead of inserting anything. The *d*-forms won.

Those four verbs — *tener*, *poner*, *venir*, *salir* — are all members of the **-go club** from Chapters 12–13, the verbs whose “I” form ends in *-go* (*tengo*, *pongo*, *vengo*, *salgo*). The club has six members, and the other two, *hacer* and *decir*, are sitting in family 3 below. So **all six of the -go verbs are irregular here too**; they just split into two shapes. The oldest, most-used verbs misbehave in the same places over and over.

3. Chop hard. Two verbs shorten drastically.

Verb	Future	Conditional
<i>decir</i> (to say)	<i>diré</i>	<i>diría</i>
<i>hacer</i> (to do)	<i>haré</i>	<i>haría</i>

Grammar Lens

Here is the test that covers every irregular in this chapter: they are irregular in the **stem only**. The endings never change.

irregular stem + the same *-é* / *-ás* / *-á* / *-emos* / *-án* (future) or *-ía* / *-ías* / *-íamos* / *-ían* (conditional).

One more use, and it surprises everyone: Spanish uses the **future** to express **present guessing**.

Spanish	Means
<i>¿Dónde estará Juan?</i>	“Where can Juan be?” (right now)
<i>Serán las tres.</i>	“It must be three o’clock.”
<i>¿Quién será?</i>	“Who could that be?”

And the **conditional** does the same job for the **past**: *Serían las tres cuando llegó* — “It must have been three when he arrived.”

Why it’s said this way

This looks arbitrary until you remember where these tenses came from. Both were built out of “**I have to...**” — and *have to* is about **obligation and likelihood**, not only about time. English does the very same slide: “it *must* be three” is a word of obligation used for a guess. Spanish just made the whole tense carry that double duty.

- *¿Qué harás mañana?*
- *Hablaré con Susana. ¿Podrías venir?*
- *Me gustaría, pero tendré que trabajar. ¿Qué hora es?*
- *Serán las tres.*

Run the recall. What do the future *and* conditional endings attach to? The **whole infinitive** — you never strip it. What happened to Latin’s own future? It **died**, and Romance replaced it with the phrase **infinitive + habēre**, “I have to speak.” So what are the endings really? The **present of haber** for the future, the **imperfect of haber** for the conditional. Which

language still shows the seam? **Portuguese**, in *falá-lo-ei*. Do the irregulars change the endings or the stem? **The stem only.** Why does *tener* become *tendr-*? Dropping the vowel squeezed *-n'r-* together and a **d** wedged in to fix it. Which two verbs chop hardest? *decir* → *diré* and *hacer* → *haré*. And what does *Serán las tres* mean? “It must be three” — the future used for guessing. Next chapter: the subjunctive, the mood for things that are not facts.

Chapter 18

The Subjunctive — the Mood of the Not-Yet-Real

Every verb form so far has *asserted* something. This chapter opens the other door: a whole second set of endings reserved for what is wanted, doubted, hoped for — for what has not happened and may never happen. It is built by one small trick, triggered by one simple test, and its name means “joined underneath.” *Practice lessons: lessons/ES-C18-*.md.*

18.1 *hable, coma, viva* — building the present subjunctive

Grammar Lens

What a mood is. A **tense** tells you *when*: I speak, I spoke, I will speak. A **mood** tells you what the speaker is *doing* with the sentence — reporting it, or reaching for it.

Everything in this book up to now has been the **indicative**: the mood of assertion. It states how things are, and it keeps on stating even when it is guessing — *Serán las tres* (“it must be three o’clock”) is still an assertion, just a confident one about something unknown.

Spanish has a second mood for what is not asserted at all: things wanted, doubted, feared, hoped for. That is the **subjunctive**. English has a shrunken one left over in fixed phrases — “if I **were** you” (not *was*), “I insist that he **be** here” (not *is*), “God **save** the Queen” (not *saves*). Those odd forms are English’s last subjunctives. Spanish never let its own wear away.

The recipe — and it does not start from the infinitive. It starts from the *yo* (“I”) form of the present tense.

1. Take the *yo* form: *hablo* (“I speak”), *como* (“I eat”), *vivo* (“I live”).
2. Drop the *-o*: *habl-*, *com-*, *viv-*.
3. Add the **opposite** vowel.

“Opposite” is the whole trick. The two verb families swap costumes.

Verb type	Present takes...	Subjunctive takes...
<i>-ar</i>	<i>-a-</i> (hablas)	-e- (hables)
<i>-er / -ir</i>	<i>-e- / -i-</i> (comes)	-a- (comas)

	<i>hablar</i> (to speak)	<i>comer</i> (to eat)	<i>vivir</i> (to live)
yo	hable	coma	viva
tú	hables	comas	vivas
él / ella / usted	hable	coma	viva
nosotros	hablemos	comamos	vivamos
ellos / ustedes	hablen	coman	vivan

Notice that *-er* and *-ir* verbs are **identical** here — *coma* and *viva* take exactly the same endings. Outside the present tense, those two conjugations keep merging.

Grammar Lens

Why building from *yo* is a gift. Because the subjunctive is built from the *yo* form, *any* irregularity already sitting in that form is inherited automatically. The **-go club** — six very common verbs whose “I” form grows a hard *g* — transfers whole, with nothing new to memorise.

Verb	<i>yo</i> form	Subjunctive
<i>tener</i> (to have)	tengo	tenga
<i>decir</i> (to say)	digo	diga
<i>hacer</i> (to do / make)	hago	haga
<i>poner</i> (to put)	pongo	ponga
<i>salir</i> (to leave)	salgo	salga
<i>venir</i> (to come)	vengo	venga

The **stem-changers** — verbs whose stressed vowel breaks into two — come along on the same free ride:

Verb	<i>yo</i> form	Subjunctive
<i>querer</i> (to want)	quiero	quiera
<i>poder</i> (to be able)	puedo	pueda

One caution: for these, the *nosotros* form keeps the **plain** stem — *queramos*, *podamos*, never *quieramos*. That is the same rule as the present tense: the stress falls elsewhere, so the broken vowel never appears.

Where the recipe runs out. Step two says “drop the *-o*,” so the recipe needs a *yo* form with a strippable *-o* on the end. Five very common verbs do not have one.

Verb	<i>yo</i> form	Subjunctive	
<i>ser</i> (to be)	soy	sea	unpredictable
<i>ir</i> (to go)	voy	vaya	unpredictable
<i>saber</i> (to know)	sé	sepa	unpredictable
<i>haber</i> (to have, auxiliary)	he	haya	unpredictable
<i>estar</i> (to be)	estoy	esté	predictable

The first four are simply learned outright — and *sea* carries a footnote.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sea (“that it be”) ← Latin *sedeam*, the subjunctive of *sedēre*, “**to sit**” — the second Latin verb that got folded into Spanish *ser*. *Sea* comes from that sitting verb’s own subjunctive. The wanderer turns up again here, at the far end of the grammar.

But *estar* behaves differently. Strip off the *whole -oy* and a perfectly ordinary stem is left — **est-** — which then takes the normal *-ar* endings: *esté*, *estés*, *esté*, *estemos*, *estén*.

Sounds you’ll need

estar’s one real oddity is **stress**, not spelling. Spanish’s default: a word ending in a **vowel**, **-n** or **-s** is stressed on the **second-to-last** syllable. *hablar* obeys that all the way through — **HA**-ble, ha-**BLE**-mos, **HA**-blen — so it never needs a written mark.

estar breaks it. The stress lands on the **last** syllable: es-**TÉ**, es-**TÉS**, es-**TÉN** — so each of those carries a written accent. Only es-**TE**-mos falls where Spanish expects, and it takes none.

The written accents are not decoration and not arbitrary: they are the *receipt* for a stress that does not sit where the language expects it.

So the honest count is **four irregular, plus one** whose stem is perfectly regular but whose stress is not.

(*dar*, “to give,” has the same *-oy* tail — *doy* — and its stem shrinks the same way, down to *d-*: **dé, des, dé, demos, den**. Careful, though: that single accent is *not* a stress mark. *Dé* is one syllable; the mark is there only to keep the verb apart in writing from the little preposition *de*, “of.”)

Grammar Lens

A caution about *why*. “No *-o* to strip” is a **memory aid for the modern language**, not the history. *sea, vaya, sepa* and *haya* come down from Latin *sedeam, vādam, sapiam* and *habeam*; and *saber* and *haber* plainly do have usable stems elsewhere, *sab-* and *hab-*. The *yo*-form recipe is a superb shortcut, and these five are exactly where it stops describing the language.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

subjunctive ← Latin *subiūnctīvus*, “**joined underneath**” — *sub-* (“under”) + *iungere* (“to join”). English **join, junction** and **conjunction** all descend from that verb.

Two more words belong to the family without descending from Latin: **yoke** (a native English word, Old English *geoc*) and **yoga** (Sanskrit *yuj-*, literally “a yoking”). Those are *iungere*’s **cousins**, not its children — all three go back to the same Proto-Indo-European root **yewg-*, “to join.” A yoke is what joins two oxen; yoga is what joins the self to something larger; a conjunction is what joins two clauses.

Latin coined the term to translate Greek *hypotaktikē*, “**subordinated**.” So the name describes where the mood *lives*, not what it means: in a clause hanging **underneath** another one. The next section shows exactly that structure.

18.2 *quiero que...* — making the subjunctive appear

You can now *build* the subjunctive. This section is about what makes it *show up* — and the core case is beautifully simple: **one person wanting a different person to do something**.

Spanish	English
Quiero hablar español.	I want to speak Spanish.
Quiero que hables español.	I want you to speak Spanish.

Grammar Lens

The first sentence has **one** subject — I want, I speak — so Spanish uses a plain infinitive, exactly like English.

The second has **two**. *I* am the wanter; *you* are the speaker. The moment the two subjects differ, Spanish must do two things: (1) join the halves with **que** (“that”), and (2) put the second verb in the **subjunctive**.

Quiero que hables.

That is *subiūnctīvus* doing precisely what its name says: living in a clause joined *underneath* the main one.

Why it is not a fact. *Hables* is not a report that you speak. It is what I *want* — which may never happen. The main clause reaches out and bends the second one into something unreal, and the mood marks the bend.

Spanish	English	Mood
Sé que hablas español.	I know that you speak Spanish.	indicative (a fact)
Quiero que hables español.	I want you to speak Spanish.	subjunctive (not yet real)

Same *que*, same person, different mood — because knowing *reports* the world and wanting tries to *change* it.

Grammar Lens

The English trap. English says “I want *you to speak*” — an object followed by an infinitive. **After verbs of wanting, Spanish will not do this.** There is no *Quiero te hablar* meaning “I want you to speak.” You must build the full clause: **Quiero que hables.** This is the single

most common English-speaker error with the Spanish subjunctive, and it comes from translating the *shape* instead of the *meaning*.

Two things keep the rule honest. First, it is about **wanting**, not about Spanish in general: object + infinitive is perfectly good after verbs of *perceiving* and *causing* — *Te vi salir* (“I saw you leave”), *Me hizo hablar* (“he made me speak”), *Déjame hablar* (“let me speak”). Volition is the family that demands a clause. Second, *Quiero hablarte* is perfectly fine — it just means “I want to *speak to you*”: one subject, with the pronoun attached to the infinitive. What is impossible is using a pronoun to smuggle in a *second* subject.

ojalá — a wish, borrowed whole. Spanish has another trigger, and it is a wonderful word: **Ojalá hable español** — “I hope he speaks Spanish / may he speak Spanish.” *Ojalá* takes the subjunctive **always**; there is no indicative version, because the word *is* a wish.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ojalá (“would that...”) ← Andalusí Arabic *law shā’ Allāh*, “**if God should will**.” The *Allāh* is still sitting in the second half of the word every time a Spanish speaker says it. The nearest English is “**God willing**” — and nearer still, the Arabic *inshallah* that English has now borrowed in its own right.

Why it’s said this way

Languages borrow *nouns* constantly: Spanish took *azúcar* (“sugar”), *aceite* (“oil”) and *álgebra* from Arabic without blinking. Borrowing a **function word** — a piece of the machinery rather than a piece of the furniture — is far rarer, and this course teaches you the two that matter: **hasta** (“until”), from Arabic *hattā*, and **ojalá**. One is a preposition; the other is a word that *forces a grammatical mood*. Eight centuries of contact left Spanish not just Arabic words, but Arabic grammar.

18.3 Practice — fact or wish?

Two skills to drill, in order: **build the form**, then **decide whether you need it**.

Drill 1 — the vowel flip. Recipe: *yo* form → drop the *-o* → flip the vowel.

Verb	<i>yo</i> form	Subjunctive
<i>hablar</i>	hablo	hable
<i>estudiar</i>	estudio	estudie
<i>comer</i>	como	coma
<i>beber</i>	bebo	beba
<i>vivir</i>	vivo	viva
<i>tener</i>	tengo	tenga
<i>hacer</i>	hago	haga
<i>venir</i>	vengo	venga
<i>querer</i>	quiero	quiera
<i>poder</i>	puedo	pueda

The last four are the point: **you never learned a new stem**. The *-g-* and the broken vowel were already sitting in the *yo* form.

Then the four with no *-o* to strip, learned outright: *ser* → **sea**, *ir* → **vaya**, *saber* → **sepa**, *haber* → **haya**. And *estar*, which looks as though it belongs with them and does not: take off the whole *-oy* and the stem **est-** is completely ordinary — *esté*, *estés*, *esté*, *estemos*, *estén* — with the irregularity living in the **stress** alone.

Drill 2 — one subject or two? The test: *does the second verb have a different subject?*

English	Spanish
I want to eat.	Quiero comer . (same subject → infinitive)
I want you to eat.	Quiero que comas . (two → <i>que</i> + subjunctive)
We want to live here.	Queremos vivir aquí.
We want them to live here.	Queremos que vivan aquí.
She wants to work.	Quiere trabajar .
She wants me to work.	Quiere que yo trabaje .

Say each pair aloud back to back. English switches quietly, from “to eat” to “you to eat”; Spanish switches loudly — and the loudness is the help.

Drill 3 — fact or not? Same *que*, different mood. Report the world → **indicative**. Reach for it → **subjunctive**.

Spanish	English	
Sé que comes aquí.	I know you eat here.	fact
Quiero que comas aquí.	I want you to eat here.	wish
Sé que está aquí.	I know he's here.	fact
Ojalá esté aquí.	I hope he's here.	wish
Dice que viene .	She says she's coming.	report
Quiero que venga .	I want her to come.	wish

Notice that *ojalá* needs no *que* and no main verb. The word *is* the wish, so it triggers the mood all by itself.

Drill 4 — hear the flip. The vowel swap is small on paper and clear in the mouth.

Indicative	Subjunctive
habla	hable
come	coma
trabaja	trabaje
vive	viva

Sounds you'll need

The two *-ar* rows carry a warning. *Hable* and *hablé* are different words — and so are *trabaje* and *trabajé*. The written accent is the only thing separating “(that) he speak” from “I spoke.” In Spanish the accent does not merely mark a syllable: it *carries the tense*.

What you built this chapter: a second **mood**, made from the *yo* form with the vowel flipped — *hable*, *coma*, *viva*; the free ride that hands you *tenga*, *diga*, *haga*, *ponga*, *salga*, *venga*, *quiera*, *pueda*; the four you learn outright, *sea*, *vaya*, *sepa*, *haya*, and *esté*, whose only secret is its stress; the two-subject test that summons the mood, *quiero que hables*; and *ojalá*, a wish that Spanish carried over whole from Arabic. You now have both halves of the Spanish verb: the mood that reports the world, and the mood that reaches for it. Everything still ahead — describing what surrounds you, telling longer stories, arguing, hoping out loud — is built on the pair.